THE END OF THE LINE

FROM LEFT: Cox wears a **Dunhill** suit. Madekwe, in a **Valentino** top, says that "nothing can prepare you for doing eight shows a week—you start feeling like an athlete." Walter, in **Dolce & Gabbana Alta Moda,** proclaims that she "will always believe in theater as an instrument for change, entertainment, wonder, and excitement." In this story: makeup, Lisa Houghton. Details, see In This Issue.

PRODUCED BY FARAGO PROJECTS. PRODUCTION DESIGN:
MARY HOWARD. SET DECORATION: LEE FLUDE. SPECIAL THANKS
TO BRITISH PULLMAN, A BELMOND TRAIN, ENGLAND.

RAW MATERIAL

GRUNGE IS ALIVE AND WELL IN 2026—BUT INSTEAD OF OVERSIZED FLANNELS AND DITSY FLORALS, ITS NEW ERA IS DEFINED BY GAUZY LAYERS, DISTRESSED DENIM, AND A MINIMAL, UNDONE SENSE OF EASE. PHOTOGRAPHED BY COLLIER SCHORR.

HIGH CONTRAST
It's all about balance—just ask Gigi Hadid, who wears a sumptuous, buttery silk **Givenchy by Sarah Burton** top (givenchy.com) with rough-and-tumble distressed **Levi's** from Mothfood Shop. OPPOSITE: In a lacy **Tom Ford** dress (tomfordfashion.com), model Vittoria Ceretti nods to a '90s take on lingerie dressing. Fashion Editor: Camilla Nickerson.

LAYER IT ON ME
Model Liu Wen goes more-is-more with an **Hermès** jacket (Hermès boutiques), **Brooks Brothers** blazer, and a **Michael Kors Collection** shirt (michaelkors.com). OPPOSITE: Model Anok Yai keeps it easy breezy in airy **Miu Miu**; miumiu.com.

Authority Given
Movement w/ eye contact assumes
ono vs. Bausch

COME AS YOU ARE
Ceretti has it both ways in a **Brooks Brothers** shirt (brooksbrothers.com) and **Hodakova** pants apron (hodakova .com). OPPOSITE: Liu shadow dances in **Tod's**; tods.com.

FINDING NIRVANA
What better way to bring an ethereal dress back down to earth than with a pair of well-worn jeans and clunky boots? Ceretti styles a multi-patterned **Chanel** dress (select Chanel boutiques) with paint-splattered jeans from **eBay** and vintage military boots from **The Quality Mending Co.**

FINE LINES
Yai grounds a buoyant lace **Dior** dress with stone-washed **Dior** jeans (Dior boutiques).

STATE OF THE ART

TOP: Model Noor Khan gets down to essentials in a **Michael Kors Collection** bodysuit (michaelkors.com) and **Calvin Klein Collection** trousers (calvinklein.us for requests). BOTTOM: A **Tom Ford** leather shirt worn over a delicate slip also does the trick; tomfordfashion.com. OPPOSITE: Model Alex Consani—in **Prada**; prada.com—makes a state of disarray look well-considered.

THE MORE THE MERRIER

Model Selena Forrest's embellished mesh **Prada** dress adds intrigue to an otherwise minimal look; prada.com. **Courrèges** jeans; courreges.com. **Phoebe Philo** shoes.

PRODUCED BY HEN'S TOOTH PRODUCTION. SET DESIGN: JAVIER IRIGOYEN. ILLUSTRATIONS AND COLLAGES: COLLIER SCHORR.

OFF THE WALL
Hadid in a formfitting **Gucci** jacket and trousers; gucci.com. In this story: hair, Jimmy Paul; makeup, Yumi Lee. Details, see In This Issue.

BEAUTY NOTE
Hold, please. Safe for sensitive skin, hydrating niacinamide in Maybelline Grippy Serum plumps and preps as a first step to help makeup last.

ARYNA UNCHAINED

ARYNA SABALENKA—TENNIS'S HARD-HITTING, HEART-ON-HER-SLEEVE WORLD NUMBER ONE—UNDERSTANDS THAT HER SPORT IS OPERA. BY ROB HASKELL. PHOTOGRAPHED BY STEVEN KLEIN.

By the time she landed in Madrid, in mid-April of this year, Aryna Sabalenka had polished her game to such a dazzling gleam that losing was starting to seem impossible. Her famously forceful ground strokes were painting the lines. The angles seemed especially severe, the serve especially clutch. Never a great mover, she was starting to rush the net, adding even more pressure to her already smothering game. Sabalenka, 28, was playing like she believed she could do anything—and maybe she was right. After years of frenetic jostling for position at the top of the women's game, it was beginning to look like she might be not just the number one tennis player in the world—as she had been for the last 70-odd weeks—but truly dominant atop the sport in the manner of two of her idols, Serena Williams and Steffi Graf. What was more, the spring chatter among tennis mavens extended beyond her indomitable game: She seemed to be…growing up.

In Indian Wells, California, a few weeks earlier, she had defeated her recent nemesis, the taciturn Elena Rybakina of Kazakhstan. Still flusterable, still a bundle of facial expressions, her grunts set off by her opponent's silence, Sabalenka had the crowd eating out of her hand. She shouted in frustration, and the stadium cheered: call and response. "She's in control," said the white-haired woman next to me. "She used to expend a lot of her energy getting angry. And then she'd lose."

Two weeks later, in Miami, Sabalenka won the second of the important spring tournaments—an elusive tennis laurel known as the Sunshine Double. It was also the month she adopted a Cavalier King Charles spaniel puppy, named Ash after tennis great Arthur Ashe, and got engaged to Georgios Frangulis, a Greek Brazilian businessman and the founder of Oakberry, an acai-bowl brand with more than 800 stores in over 50 countries. Bearing two big trophies and wearing a 12-carat oval diamond ring (conceived by Frangulis and executed by her friend the Miami-based jewelry designer Isabela Grutman), Sabalenka was reveling. She told commentators from the Tennis Channel that it was the single best month of her life.

Then April came. In Madrid, on the red clay of the Caja Mágica, for the first time in 16 matches, she lost—squandering six match points against the young 32nd-ranked American Hailey Baptiste. "That wasn't an easy one," Sabalenka says a few days later in the living room of the largest suite at the Bvlgari Hotel in Rome, where the season's clay court swing has brought her next. "The night I lost, I dreamed of all those match points. I would dream about a point, then I would wake up and I'd think about that missed opportunity."

The enfilade of rooms, with views onto the Mausoleum of Augustus, is a sanctuary of beige and gold dotted with Italian modernist furniture and century-old Gio Ponti ceramics. Sabalenka is a paragon of post-practice coziness in a brown NikeSkims zip-up shirt and pale yellow Nike sweats; her neck, earlobes, and ring finger ablaze with diamonds. I am worried about Ash, whose nomadic existence has made housebreaking all but impossible. (So far it's been grass-scented wee-wee pads in hotel suites, though Sabalenka says that he's using them faithfully.)

Losses—and there would be several more this season—present the champion with a conundrum: brush them off and move forward or study them, unpuzzle them? "It's a learning process. If I didn't really care and was like, *Whatever, on to the next one,* I wouldn't learn," she says. "That would be unhealthy. That's the tough side of being an athlete: You cannot win everything. But it's also the beauty of sport. It's nice, too, when somebody young and up-and-coming beats the world number one. If somebody won everything, it wouldn't exactly be entertaining to watch." If Sabalenka has become a star, it's in part because she understands that tennis can be opera. To grab your audience, give them human behavior across four wailed octaves: triumph and despair, love and heartache, grace and slapstick, sin and atonement.

Like the story of many elite athletes, Sabalenka's begins with a little girl who had too much energy and too few ways of defusing it. Born and raised in Minsk, the capital of Belarus, she first picked up a racket at six. "In our region, the two most popular sports are ice hockey and tennis," she explains. "My dad chose tennis." She remembers Minsk, a city of two million people, as safe, quiet, comfortable, and immaculate. Littering, she says, "would be considered animal behavior there," and the neighborhood where she spent her childhood was so secure that she could roam the streets with friends until late into the night without her mother worrying. Her father, who had been a serious hockey player before a near-fatal motorcycle crash derailed the dream of a professional career, ran a successful car-repair business. Her mother did not work, but she held two university degrees and prioritized her daughters' education. (Sabalenka has a sister, 11 years younger, who is not a tennis player and reportedly finds the sport "so boring.")

"Until I was maybe 13, we were wealthy," Sabalenka recalls. "And then my dad struggled. So many setbacks. I watched him struggle many times in his career but always get up. My parents tried hard to keep things going, and we didn't really talk about it. But I knew. Parents think we don't know, but we know." Sabalenka and her father were especially close, and it's clear that she identifies with his resilience. But he was not the sort of unyielding tennis dad of whom the women's tour, especially, has had countless examples over the years. "He was always telling me, 'If you don't like it, if you want to quit, just tell us. You don't have to force yourself to do anything.' There was a period when I was probably nine when I was close to giving up. But I saw how proud my dad was of me, and I didn't want to disappoint him. And then I fell in love again with the sport, much more than before."

Sabalenka wasn't exactly a late bloomer, but she was not pushed onto the professional tour as a 15-year-old, as many of her peers were. She did not win her first Women's Tennis Association main-draw match until she was 19, at Wimbledon. Belarus did not have a munificent state-sponsored tennis program like China, Russia, and France, and in the early days she struggled to find consistent instruction. "So many coaches told me that I was stupid, and that the only thing I could do was overhit the ball—that I would never reach the top 100," she remembers.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 372

PRODUCED BY THAT ONE PRODUCTION. LOCATION: FAENA MIAMI BEACH.

VIEW FROM HERE

"Aryna's going to say what she feels. That makes her special," says Sabalenka's fiancé, Georgios Frangulis. Sabalenka, photographed at the Faena Miami Beach, wears a Gucci dress and Material Good earrings. Hair, Sandy Hullett; makeup, Mark Carrasquillo. Details, see In This Issue.

Fashion Editor: Tonne Goodman.

Inside Demna's GUCCIVERSE

In a mere dozen or so years, the Georgia-born designer has gone from Vetements' wild child to the top of Gucci. Nathan Heller revisits fashion's restless disrupter as he sets about reinvigorating a global mega-brand. Portrait by Rineke Dijkstra.

On a bright, crisp February morning in Milan, a day before a make-or-break show, Demna, once the leading iconoclast of French fashion and now the artistic director of Gucci, tours his offices with a curious air of calm.

"Obviously, I'm a bit stressed—but I feel good," he says, raking his eyes around a studio trimmed in a style unmistakably his own. A pair of leather sofas rest near full-length windows. Patchwork curtains by the artist Pia Camil trace the wall. When, a decade ago, Gucci moved into this sleek array of buildings on the industrial Via Mecenate, the brand managed to reassert its reputation as something like the Italian sports car of fashion—a streamlined, leather-bound vehicle with a brisk, outlandish kick—an image that has since become ensconced in popular culture. "My cousin, who is 16 and spends her life on Roblox, heard that I was going to Gucci and was like, 'Do you know Gucci is a word we use a lot to describe a certain state of mind? If you *feel Gucci,* it means you want to be crazy and meet people and be out there,'" Demna says. He smiles and adds, "I want to make people feel Gucci tomorrow."

Demna Gvasalia, as he was born in Georgia (he doffed his surname at the peak of his ascent at Balenciaga, five years ago), is now 45, an age when designers often arrive at the mature version of themselves. Yet his voice seemed fully formed a fashion eon ago, in 2014, the year he cofounded Vetements, and mere months before he was named Balenciaga's artistic director, further widening his reach. "It made him the most influential designer of the decade," Alexandre Samson, the fashion historian and a curator at Palais Galliera, in Paris, says. "He created characters that were very clear and reflective of an Eastern, post-USSR youth culture with no money, which looked to, admired, and despised the Western world." Demna saw that this ambivalence, covetous and critical, could speak to the social-media-ruled capitals of the West too. "It was a very strong take, mixing logo mania with deconstructive patternmaking skills and sportswear," Samson says. It was intensely personal, too, and has remained so through years of reimagining since then.

In the studio, Demna wears loose black Adidas trousers, a black T-shirt bearing the logo of the heavy metal band Slipknot, and black Gucci mules—an example of the flowing baggy silhouette that he defined. When he was young, in bourgeois Europe, his personal style was often taken as provocation: He was chased from restaurants and had foodstuffs thrown at him. Since then, it has become a key template for mainstream luxury taste.

When Demna took the helm of Gucci last summer, after a decade leading Balenciaga, the move was received much in the spirit of Long John Silver winning control of the *Hispaniola.* The brand had spent a couple of years adrift; his arrival promised to make it rollick on the waves again. "He has this complete I-don't-give-a-fuck-ness about what he does, and he knows how to garner attention, how to make a moment. He has a very good tap on the cultural conscience," the model and influencer Vivian Wilson tells me. "He designs what he wants," Kim Kardashian, a longtime friend and muse of Demna's, says. "He's just so unapologetically himself."

What was less certain was whether Demna's style of attention could suit so large and mainstream a brand. Gucci is the crown jewel of Kering, the luxury conglomerate, and, in a year of industry downturns, it has become a charged bellwether too. (The company's fate is so twined with Gucci's success that the brand's CEO tells me she weaned herself off checking hour-by-hour global sales figures in bed.) "The team have a big responsibility, because they are handling a mega brand," Luca de Meo, Kering's CEO, says. "Handle with care!" Demna, who trained in the Antwerp school of conceptualism, was known as an arch, biting ironist with a taste for provocation. (An early Vetements collection included what looked like yellow dishwashing gloves.) There was a risk of this restless style straining under Gucci-scale success. At least that was the anxiety: In the studio, Demna surprises me by saying that, since arriving, he has sloughed off his conceptualism for a more immediate, sensual approach.

"Gucci is a very pragmatic brand, and it's about *product.* It's liberating not to have to conceptualize a dress just to make a dress that you love," he says. "This is how fashion should be: more intuitive and emotional…either 'I hate it' or 'I love it.'" For his first Gucci showing, he presented a capsule collection (La Famiglia) in the form of a film, exploring what he describes as the brand's essential characters based on its looks of the 1970s. His pre-fall collection was a tribute to the sexy, soigné looks that defined the house in the '90s, under Tom Ford.

On this particular day, the collection he's about to show is an account of Gucci in the present: his own vision, joining him to a generation of Belgian

HAT TRICK

"There's something daring about it," Demna says of his vision for Gucci. "It's flamboyant. It's confident. You know who you are."

Fashion Photographs by Alessio Bolzoni

TAKING SHAPE

Models Sheila Bawar and Kayako Higuchi (OPPOSITE) in Demna's reimagined proportions. "My vision of Gucci is creating this FOMO," Demna says. "The chic, the elegance, the Italian-ness of it."

Fashion Editor: Luca Galasso.

conceptualists, including Matthieu Blazy and Pieter Mulier, that discovered a new sensuality at large heritage brands. (So far, the moves have registered: While it is by most measures too early to see major sales effects, store traffic rose from the release of the first capsule collection.) From a rack hung with a few pieces that will appear on the runway the next day, Demna extracts coats that look like fur but are actually the more ubiquitous agricultural by-product, shearling, trimmed on a bias and stitched with muslin for an effect as light as a windbreaker in the hand.

Lightness is everything, Demna now thinks—lightness and speed. On arriving at Gucci, he discovered that all the studio's prototypes were sewn off-site. One of the first changes he made was to create a Gucci atelier on-site, so that garments could be made more quickly—more industrially—and edited not on paper but in the round, with pins and scissors.

Demna takes up a couple classic handbags that he also made lighter and more supple, and he shows off two exquisite dresses on mannequins—one purple, with a classic Gucci pattern; the other in shimmering gold sequins. Beyond these displays, his studio is curiously empty, as if it, too, has been subjected to a lightness regime. Demna seems suddenly aware of the absence.

"I don't want to show you too many things," he says with a playful smile. "I want the show to be a surprise."

Many people trace Demna's touch—if not his sensibility—to four spirited years he spent working at Maison Martin Margiela early in his career, overseeing the women's ready-to-wear collections. "He absolutely understood the process and the way of thinking behind the whole brand: the idea of repurposing"—Margiela, like Demna, was known for using vintage pieces as a starting point—"and the idea, also, of playing with society," Samson says. At Vetements, Demna applied these processes to his own style. There were hoodies with raised or pointed shoulders, oversized jackets. As a self-conscious young man, he had taken to wearing oversized clothes as a form of self-concealment; now, he began reshaping the normative body into new and unusual forms, to thrilling effects. "At the time, there was really *nothing* else happening in Paris," Julien Charrier, who started work as an intern at Vetements in 2016 and is now Demna's chief of staff, tells me. "He was bringing something that was completely out of the box, very fresh, very young, very street-culture." Within a year, the label was being worn—or imitated—by Jared Leto and Ye, then known as Kanye West. "He was always just so *cool*," says Kardashian, who met Demna shortly after Vetements launched, before there was a storefront, and spent hours simply trying on pieces at a holding warehouse in Paris in the middle of the night.

In 2016, Demna gave his first show at Balenciaga. (He continued designing for both labels for years.) He had hits like the chunky Triple S sneaker and the wide-collar Swing shirt, but he also reached for geopolitical themes. In March 2022, after the Russia-Ukraine war broke out, his show featured models trudging through a snowstorm in yellow and blue. Within three years, the house had doubled in size and had crossed a billion dollars in sales. *The Washington Post,* in 2019, celebrated Demna for "changing what we consider fashion."

LET IT FLOW

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: Model Amelia Gray, musician The Dare, Higuchi, and Gray in Gucci; gucci.com. "I want to do something I haven't done before, which"—Demna smiles—"limits the possibilities."

When I met Demna for the first time, late that year, he was living in the woods, in Switzerland, with his husband, the musician Loïk Gomez. Paris had become too distracting, he told me, too claustrophobic, too much. In Switzerland he saw almost no one, but every day before work, donning high boots and an overcoat, he went tramping into nature like a figure out of Caspar David Friedrich. He was planning to relaunch Balenciaga's long-dormant couture operations. He had begun to think about the body in new and poetic ways. "I'm no longer on the dark side of the world," he told me at the time.

It couldn't last. A few months later, the whole world went dark for the COVID-19 pandemic. The remote woods of Switzerland proved an oddly perfect place to endure the lockdown, but Demna's couture debut got pushed back a year. Meanwhile, the brand's apparent provocations seemed to compound. In 2022, Balenciaga severed its ties with Ye, who had been one of its most prominent and stalwart public supporters, after Ye made what was widely taken to be antisemitic posts on social media. (In January of this year, Ye apologized in a full-page advertisement in *The Wall Street Journal.*) Only weeks later, the brand—and Demna—faced public opprobrium after releasing an ad campaign which included children, dressed in its kids line, holding teddy bear bags previously shown on the runway. To many, the bears appeared to be dressed in BDSM gear. Eagle-eyed viewers noted that another ad, for a spring 2023 collection, which included a desk messed with papers, appeared to include a page of the opinion in the Supreme Court case *United States v. Williams,* which concerned child pornography.

The fallout was severe. Close celebrity affiliates of Balenciaga, including Kardashian, reevaluated their relationships with the brand. ("That was never an issue with him," Kardashian tells me. "Once we did an investigation and we saw where things happened, we were comfortable moving forward.") Soon Demna himself issued a public apology. "It was inappropriate to have kids promote objects that had nothing to do with them," he wrote. "As much as I would sometimes like to provoke a thought through my work, I would NEVER have an intention to do that with such an awful subject as child abuse that I condemn."

"Provocation is like humor, and humor cannot be stupid," he tells me now, when I ask whether the experience compelled him to reassess the role of provocation in his life and work. "It involves a kind of nuance. Provocation is stupid when you're the only person laughing."

Demna had resolved to exit the Swiss woods. "After a while, I got so bored there," he tells me. "Boredom is such a scary and tricky thing for a creative person—I always want to discover new things." He and Gomez moved into Geneva but eventually found themselves back in Paris, stimulated but restless as ever. "I love Paris, but it only works as a long-distance relationship for me," Demna tells me. "I lived there for 15 years, which is the longest I've been in one place in my life. But I didn't like what fashion started to become while I was living in Paris full-time: safe, boring, beige, wannabe bourgeois, flat, superficial—all the things fashion shouldn't be." With the thought that a part-time life in Paris was the best kind of Paris life, he and Gomez continued looking for a second perch.

They landed in LA: the city where Demna had proposed to Gomez and a place where he had always dreamed of living. They bought a 1950s bungalow and started moving in the local mix. To this day, Demna told me, he has a much more active social life in California than in Europe.

"It's radically different, culturally speaking," he tells me. "Modernity is there. It's not for no reason that Silicon Valley happened in California: There's something about feeling more free in your head

about how we do stuff, how we dress, how we express ourselves. In Europe it's much more conservative."

On taking the job at Gucci, he moved from Paris to Milan ("Also Europe, but a very different mentality, and so industrial in terms of fashion—I love it") but kept Los Angeles as his second base. "People always say, 'Oh, I get why you're there—you want to be far from fashion,' " he says. "I'm like, 'Actually, no—there I'm really in the epicenter of thinking behind how we *use* fashion.' Whereas in Italy, what I have is the product, the heritage, the history, the manufacturing—all those things that don't exist in LA."

"It's a pretty good balance," he adds. "Gucci needs both."

Backstage at his first show, Demna squeezes up and down the model lineup, which curls along a hallway thick with hairdressers and security personnel. "The feeling when someone falls in love with someone? I have it now," he tells me. "I'm also worried about one million things—the shoes, the sweat—but we can't control these things, so worrying is useless, apparently." He grins. "I read that somewhere."

The show will be held in the Palazzo delle Scintille, a large hall in Milan that Demna refashioned as a venue for Gucci. He had been inspired by the Uffizi Galleries in Florence, the house's historical and spiritual home, and, with the Uffizi's permission, had some classical statues there replicated. They line the periphery of the Palazzo's inner hall, which proceeds down coliseum-like steps to a long central corridor that will serve as the runway. "We built a museum for the show, basically," Demna says. "My idea was to put Gucci back into the spotlight of the Italian Renaissance." There were, of course, other objectives too. As guests take their seats in the Palazzo delle Scintille, someone whispers, "There are *so many* supermodels here."

True enough. The cast includes Kate Moss, Karlie Kloss, and Gabbriette, but also figures unaccustomed to the runway, such as the rappers Fakemink and Nettspend. ("I invited, in the cast, people that I always wanted to meet," Demna explains to me.)

As the house lights go down, a bright shaft appears down the runway. The model Charlie Jones steps into it, wearing a high-collar sleeveless white dress and carrying a classic black Gucci bag. The dress is tight and revealing enough to display a tattoo on the upper thigh. ("It's the most body-conscious I've ever been," Demna says. "I've had a really good therapist for 10 years and, finally, I've started to like myself.") Jones, a trans man, cross-steps briskly, followed by a gym-built man in white pants and a similar shirt. The show, like all of Demna's at Gucci, mixes men's and women's looks. "I think the idea of splitting fashion by gender is *very* old—I think there's a systemic glitch in this," he says. When the muscleman walks past, somebody cries, "*Wow.*"

Uncharacteristically for Demna, who at Balenciaga was known for his raucous, intensifying presentations, the show blooms into poetic sequined dresses and male models who walk barefoot. "It's very romantic, very like Botticelli, almost like they came off the painting in a way," he explains. "It's a different type of beauty than I've ever touched on—more classic beauty, but pushed, exaggerated." When Moss appears to end the show, in a black backless sequined dress, a cheer breaks out: An old vision is made new again.

In 1993, Demna's family fled their hometown of Sukhumi, Georgia, under threat of ethnic cleansing, and landed in Tbilisi. One of his first jobs, at 17, was translating Reuters copy for Georgian TV, and, since then, he has rarely succeeded in outrunning the news. (On September 11, 2001, as horrific reports streamed in New York, it was the young Demna who did the simultaneous translation for the Georgian audience.) Nor has he long settled in one place.

That restlessness, paradoxically, has helped to root him in his new professional home. The unimprovably named Guccio Gucci, the brand's founder and the son of a straw-hat maker, opened a shop in Florence's Via della Vigna Nuova in 1921; by the late '30s, he was making handbags. From the start, the brand offered sly winks to its self-invention: Gucci's crest did not include a soldier, as an aristocratic crest would have, but a figure carrying aloft two luggage bags. Guccio's son Aldo helped push the company into belts, shoes, and gloves and excelled at industrial improvisation. Faced with wartime scarcities, the house made handbags with bamboo handles. By 1960, it had opened a shop in New York; soon it was in London, Paris, and LA. It took on ready-to-wear fashion and jetted into the 1970s alongside celebrities such as Grace Kelly and Jackie Kennedy. In 1974, Elton John, writing of his transatlantic travels in British *Vogue,* could refer to passengers on the *SS France* as "Gucci-Pucci" and be understood.

There followed, for two decades, enough intrigue, subterfuge, betrayal, and assassination for a Jacobean play: A series of struggles between members of the Gucci family formed the basis of the 2021 movie *House of Gucci,* culminating in the murder of Maurizio Gucci and the overtaking of the brand by what subsequently became Kering. Tom Ford, then unknown, was named creative director in 1994 and within a year was credited with creating the brand's first extraordinary renaissance, moving away from bourgeois-brown fashion for a sexy, shocking new hue. A second renaissance came in 2015, with the winsomely androgynous flair of Alessandro Michele.

> "Personally, I'm in *need* of a silhouette," Demna says, "and in September I will dare myself to show it"

With Michele's departure, in 2022, the house fell back into disorder. Revenue tumbled 21 percent in 2024; in just the first half of the following year, it fell 25 percent further. Sabato De Sarno, the creative director, parted ways with the brand in 2025, and Gucci had three CEOs over two years. Last fall, Kering appointed one of its most powerful leaders, Francesca Bellettini, as Gucci's president and CEO. Her mandate, she tells me one afternoon over coffee in the Milan Four Seasons, was immediately clear: "I know that a lot of people say Gucci is like the phoenix, going up and down and reemerging from the ashes," she says. "No." She shakes her head. "We need to go up with normal growth—*and stay up.*"

Demna was Bellettini's first big notion. "I knew him from Balenciaga, which he had already decided to leave," she says. She saw a fit and put the prospect to him over dinner. "He was like, 'I can *do* it,' " she recalls. Just one thing: He wanted to study first.

"I didn't know so much about Gucci—I CONTINUED ON PAGE 374

FLOWER POWER

"He designs what he wants," says Kim Kardashian, Demna's longtime friend and muse. "He's just so unapologetically himself." In this story: hair, Esther Langham; makeup, Aaron de Mey. Details, see In This Issue.

FASHION PHOTOGRAPHS: PRODUCED BY STARKMAN & ASSOCIATES.

THE MATRIARCH

Julia Louis-Dreyfus talks to Adrienne Miller about her Broadway debut: as the genteel head of a family in *Other Desert Cities,* a celebrated play about secrets coming to light. Photographed by Annie Leibovitz.

Julia Louis-Dreyfus has reached a point in her career where she doesn't need to do anything for the first time. But on a bright summer afternoon, over a late lunch of pea soup and sashimi, she's describing not one but two new experiences: preparing for her Broadway debut and attending the Tonys.

The latter was a couple of nights ago. "I don't mean to sound corny," Louis-Dreyfus says, obviously moved. "But there's sort of an earnestness to the theater community that's beautiful. Everyone knows what the task is. And it's a mighty task."

Louis-Dreyfus's current task is becoming Polly Wyeth, the matriarch of a prominent Palm Springs family, in the revival of Jon Robin Baitz's 2011 play *Other Desert Cities,* directed by John Benjamin Hickey and opening at the Hudson Theater in October. At our lunch, in a breezy blue-and-white-striped top and white pants, Louis-Dreyfus has the warmth, charm, and ease that will serve her well as Polly—even if Polly wields these qualities with a scalpel.

Louis-Dreyfus had been looking for the right stage project for years when *Other Desert Cities* came across her desk. It's a highly literate play—Baitz's language is intelligent, witty, and caustic, in the tradition of Edward Albee—and Louis-Dreyfus was captivated. It didn't hurt that Polly is one of modern theater's most formidable creations, a country-club conservative with highly trained manners and fortress-like charm.

Short synopsis: It is Christmas Eve 2004, and Polly and Lyman Wyeth's daughter, Brooke, a writer, has returned home to Palm Springs after six years, joining her sardonic younger brother, Trip, a TV producer, as well as Polly's sister, Silda, a proud lefty uncertainly attempting sobriety. Having recovered from years of depression—treatment managed and paid for by her parents—Brooke is bearing a hand grenade: the manuscript of her forthcoming memoir (publisher: Knopf; excerpt: *The New Yorker*). It concerns her brother Henry, who, according to the family story, died in the '70s by suicide after joining a radical anti-war cult. The memoir is Brooke's reckoning with that catastrophe (Henry participated in a bombing that killed a man). But some things about the official story still seem incoherent; she doesn't have all the pieces…and isn't even sure what the pieces are.

Polly is the custodian of the family narrative, and she and Lyman consider Brooke's memoir a supreme act of betrayal, disrupting their carefully calibrated equilibrium. Ultimately, though, the play isn't entirely what it seems, and Baitz saves his most lethal move for the end—a trapdoor that reframes everything that has come before.

This is all wonderfully, wickedly funny. Louis-Dreyfus—beloved as the iconic characters Elaine Benes and Selina Meyer—will be attempting a more dangerous strain of comedy here: intimidating, elegant, poisonous, and entirely emotionally defended. Polly's humor sits atop tragedy.

The role rang all sorts of bells for Louis-Dreyfus, who grew up in New York and Washington, DC, ground zero for grande dames of the Polly Wyeth sort. "This is a woman who has her hair done a couple times a week. And her nails, the whole deal." She smiles. "I *know* these women."

She is the mother to two grown sons with her husband, Brad Hall, and has been thinking about the weight CONTINUED ON PAGE 375

PRODUCED BY AL STUDIO. SET DESIGN: LAÏLA IBRAHIM.

GRANDE DAME

"This is a woman who has her hair done a couple times a week," says Louis-Dreyfus of her character, Polly Wyeth, in *Other Desert Cities.* Ralph Lauren Collection dress. Hair, Matthew Monzon; makeup, Romy Soleimani. Details, see In This Issue.

Sittings Editor: Tabitha Simmons.

My Last Interview With David Hockney

Dodie Kazanjian remembers the late, great English painter; her husband, Calvin Tomkins; and the conversation she wishes they'd had.

For years, I asked my husband, Calvin Tomkins (his friends called him Tad), if he would write about David Hockney. He had written profiles of so many of the giants of contemporary art, starting out in the late 1950s. Tad said he was finished with profiles; it was too much reading and research and interviewing for someone who had been declared "legally blind."

"Why not just have a conversation—two old guys shooting the breeze, talking about art and life and life and art and life in the art world over the last 60 or more years?" I'd nag. (Tad told me a story about sitting next to David at a noisy dinner one night long ago, where they both had trouble hearing each other. The only thing Tad remembered was David's declarative sentence on photography: "It's a one-eyed man looking through a little 'ole.")

That wasn't to be: David Hockney died at his home in London in June, and Tad died a couple of months earlier, in March. But they did have an hour or so together last spring on Zoom, while I interviewed David for a story timed to his monumental exhibition "David Hockney 25" at the Fondation Louis Vuitton in Paris.

What do I remember? David's turquoise sweater and bespoke plaid suit made by his favorite tailor in Cannes; him lighting one cigarette off of another—no matches, no letup—and Tad observing.

I remember asking him about the pin he had on his lapel: "End Bossiness Soon." "I was going to put 'End Bossiness Now,' but then I thought that is in itself too bossy," he told me and Tad. "There's lots of bossy people around now, more than there used to be," he informed us, inhaling defiantly.

Tad did not write about David, but instead wrote a diary about his 100th year that was published in *The New Yorker.* It received so much attention that Tad exclaimed with a kind of childlike wonder on his birthday, "I'm back, it's a new century, and I'm famous."

Tad worked right up to the last day of his sentient life, finishing his book, *Centenarian,* which will be published next year.

Just last night, an artist friend in town from Dublin came to visit me, and we were talking about who was the most famous living artist. Of course, David Hockney dominated the conversation.

The conversation between David and Tad, two old guys talking about life in the art world, never happened—but I like to think they're having it now. □

LOOKING BACK
Hockney's painting *Le Parc des Sources, Vichy,* 1970.

FULL FLOWER
"We're pretty demanding," Ortega Pérez (wearing Zara in the gardens outside her home in northwestern Spain) says of her extended clan, many of whom work for the company today.
Sittings Editor: Karl Templer.

Family Ties

Marta Ortega Pérez, 42, leads Zara and its parent company, Inditex—the biggest fashion retailer in the world—by focusing on relationships, image-making, and a mind-blowing infrastructure. By Gaby Wood. Photographed by Annie Leibovitz.

In an industrial zone in Arteixo, at the furthest northwestern tip of Spain, amid granite quarries and aluminum merchants, Inditex, the company that owns Zara, has built a city of glass. Within it there are offices, factories, warehouses, photography studios, design departments, ateliers, a logistics center, showrooms complete with artful storefronts—all designed to fulfill desires at lightning speed.

On a top floor, the online team runs at least two fashion shoots at a time, ready to drop new products twice a week. Across a walkway in the sky, banks of sewing machines are operated by 100 seamstresses in a room the size of a small airport. On the third floor of a new building dedicated to Zara's commercial operations, a vast screen connects to shopping tills in 1,495 stores worldwide and shows what is—or isn't—selling, so the in-house designers can quickly adapt. As this detailed information filters through to the people who decide how to give the customers what they want, robots mow the expansive lawns and young forests grow. There are restaurants, of course, as well as bicycles and motorized scooters—although, if you're the boss overseeing the company's 163,000 employees and you need to get to another building in a hurry, sometimes it's quicker to take a car.

Marta Ortega Pérez, the 42-year-old nonexecutive chair of the Inditex board and the youngest daughter of its founder, presides over this futuristic complex with a democratic hand. Unassuming in her affect and understated in her dress, with a shaggy blond bob, Marta greets me warmly and leads me from the basement parking area through an indoor landscape of light. She knows everyone: Many Inditex staffers are her relatives, and she's known others for decades. A large number of them are based in La Coruña, the nearby port town where Zara has its roots. "I can't help seeing you as a five-year-old president," Loreto García Falque, a long-standing friend of Marta's mother, says with affectionate pride as she comes to greet us on the tour.

To the wider world, the Ortegas are intensely private. Marta's father, Amancio, now 90, almost never gives interviews, and Marta only rarely does. But to Inditex staff, these two are present and visible every day. "It's a very flat organization," Marta explains, leading me past her desk in the middle of an open-plan workshop, close to that of her father—who famously left school at 13 to become a delivery boy for a shirtmaker before opening the first Zara store in 1975.

"We don't have many titles. It's a very big company, but for us, from the inside, it doesn't feel that way. In the end we're like a family, and I think that's what creates the magic."

Under Marta's aegis, Zara has elevated itself by association while remaining true to what she describes as its founding premise: that "beautiful things, well-designed things, shouldn't be only for certain people. Social class," she adds, "has nothing to do with style." She has forged unions with designers and cultural figures, from Steven Meisel to Vincent Van Duysen, Marisa Berenson to Luca Guadagnino, and John Galliano to Bad Bunny, turning Zara from "a high street thing," as her friend Pieter Mulier, the Versace chief creative officer, puts it, to "a brand that's not only bigger in turnover, but bigger in impact on culture, on aesthetics, and on fashion." The results speak for themselves: Inditex is the world's largest fashion retailer and also owns brands such as Massimo Dutti and Bershka, but the various incarnations of Zara and Zara Home account for almost three quarters of its revenue. Marta has worked for the company for just under 20 years and has been chair of the board for four. Last year, Inditex's net profit was 6.2 billion euros, up 91.8 percent on the last financial year under the company's previous leadership. They're also ahead of their competitors in terms of sustainability: According to François Souchet, founder of Swanstant, a firm that forecasts how climate affects economic outcomes, "Inditex has been both posting the strongest operating margin in the industry and the lowest emission intensity."

Aside from Marta herself, a few persuasive factors recur in conversation with Zara's collaborators. First, the family feeling appears to be contagious. "There's something about the conviviality of that particular company," says the photographer David Sims, who has worked for Zara for 15 years. "It's really relaxed and a lot of fun." Second, creative people are supported in doing what they want. As Marta's friend Linda Evangelista puts it, "This is what I love about Marta: She lets the artist shine. She hires people for who they are, and her admiration is genuine." And—not least—seemingly every fashion insider who has visited the Inditex headquarters at Arteixo has been stunned by its systems.

When the Zara team got together with Bad Bunny to discuss a multipart collaboration, Marta explains, they shared a language and a sense of the importance of family. But it was the company's innovative infrastructure that allowed them to throw in the Super Bowl Halftime Show. As Marta's husband, Carlos Torretta Echevarría, who, as Zara's head of communications, was involved in the discussions, points out: Who else could make clothing for 700 dancers in two weeks?

Galliano, whose first collection for Zara will hit stores in late September, first came to Arteixo when Marta invited him to give a talk to Inditex staff. "I was quite blown away," he tells me. "It was like a James Bond setup, really, how stuff could be moved around the world. I was like, 'Wow—I've worked in ready-to-wear, darling, but this: This is incredible!' "

In a private room at Inditex HQ—I've lost track by now of which building we're in—Marta and I are served lunch. Everything is discreetly delivered: the opening salad, the filet steak, the chocolate dessert molded into a cacao pod. The room is filled with the comforting smell of Zara Home's Basilicum candles. The aura is luxurious. And yet, Marta makes clear as we eat together, "we're a long way from wanting to be a luxury brand. Luxury does an incredible job and inspires us all a lot, but we don't want to change what Zara is. We want to produce a well-made product that reaches the maximum number of people."

TALL ORDERS

The gardens at Ortega Pérez's home were designed by the acclaimed English landscape architect and garden designer Tom Stuart-Smith.

After the brand celebrated its 50th anniversary last year, they moved on quickly. "We're not great celebrators here," Marta says with an ironic smile. "Yes, those 50 years deserved to be honored, but the past is more important as a reminder of our mistakes—it's better not to repeat them than to celebrate our successes."

If this sounds tough, it's in keeping with the Ortega family's exacting nature. ("We're very demanding," Marta says of her entire clan.) Karl Templer, a Zara creative director, tells me that, because of the company's work ethic—Marta's in particular—"you want to do a really good job for her. She inspires people to bring something to the table."

Over the months that I've observed Marta, I've wondered how best to convey her particular mix of warmth and cool. There's no question that she is, as people who know her well have said to me in Spanish, *cercana.* The word literally means "close" and loosely translates, in this case, as a gift for friendship. Marta is a noticer—of how you feel, of what you like, of whether you might need anything. If anyone at work is ill, they'll get a message from Marta. If she invites you to dinner, your whole family is welcome. If you're her friend, she'll never miss a birthday. After she bonded with Galliano over their love of Ernest Hemingway, Galliano was astounded to soon receive a signed first edition of *A Farewell to Arms,* with the pages still uncut. When Inditex's CEO, Óscar García Maceiras, told me that attention to detail was one of Marta's strengths, I expected him to mean the design of a sleeve or the buckle on a bag; the example he gave instead was this: He had told Marta of an employee working at a Zara store in a faraway country who wanted to be closer to their family in Spain. Marta immediately got in touch and found the employee a job nearby. "I'll tell you something," Evangelista says, "she's a real woman's woman. Very supportive, very family-oriented."

Yet Marta also has the low-key allure of someone not entirely easy to impress. She is "rigorous and mathematical and direct," in Pieter Mulier's expression—something he finds rare in the fashion world. "She has a very clear opinion, and you get it in a second." She can be laconic. Her dark, expressive eyebrows and the deep timbre of her voice stand in entertaining contrast to the bounding energy of her husband, who is urgently sociable.

Pierpaolo Piccioli understood these different sides to her. Marta had been his client for two years when he designed four Valentino couture outfits for her wedding in 2018. He imagined three sleek, understated looks, and then had another idea: a romantic pink moiré strapless gown with an exaggerated bow. He suggested she wear it with combat boots. "It's not me," Marta said instantly. Five minutes later, she texted back: "You're right." She danced in it until three in the morning.

Zara's life began when Amancio Ortega and his first wife, the late Rosalía Mera, decided to start making quilted bathrobes and lingerie in their living room. The lingerie, which was considered somewhat risqué, met a need in the Spanish consumer that was beginning to be admissible as the Franco regime came to an end. The first Zara store opened in the couple's hometown of La Coruña, and the company expanded across Spain and Portugal over the next decade. In 1989 they opened a shop in New York, giving rise to the phrase "fast fashion" when the *The New York Times* reported that Zara catered to customers who "change their clothes as often as they change the color of their lipstick."

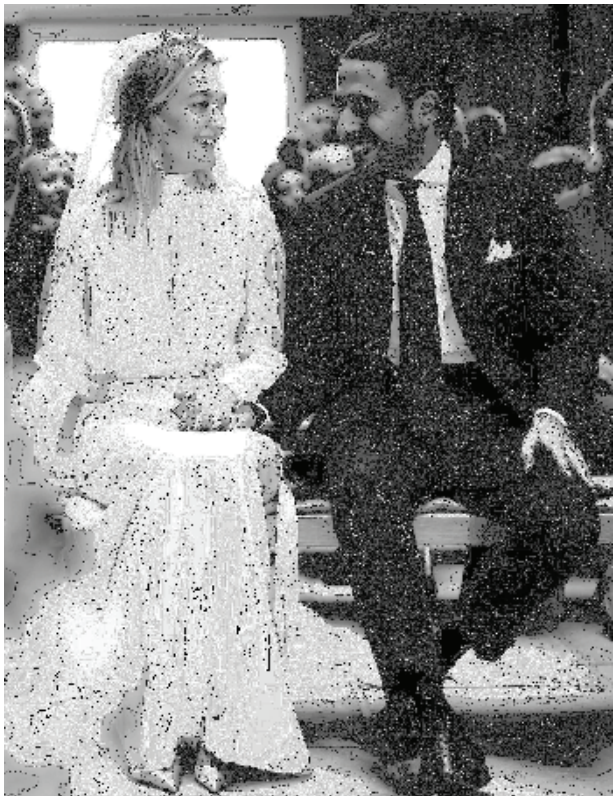
Into this world was born a girl who noticed everything. Those who knew Marta as a child recall her large, watchful eyes and attest to her being as observant then as she is now. The only child of Ortega and his second wife, Flora Pérez, Marta spent a lot of time with her maternal grandmother while her parents were working at Zara. "My grandmother is probably the person who's had the greatest impact on me," Marta reflects. "She brought up eight children. She never cared where anyone was from or what they did for a living—the only things that mattered to her were whether people were hardworking and honest."

While her grandmother helped her make clothes for her dolls, it was a British nanny who first took Marta horseback riding in La Coruña. By the age of 10, she was hooked.

"I competed as a show jumper for many years," she says—and while she didn't jump professionally, it became a big part of her life. When she went to business school in London, she competed on weekends, and when she started working on the Zara shop floor on the King's Road, she did the same. After she had her eldest son, Amancio, with her first husband, the Olympic show jumper Sergio Álvarez Moya, she returned to competition but increasingly found that she wanted to spend her weekends with her son. "Now I have less time and more children," she says succinctly. "When my daughter was born, I stopped—to compete at that level, you need to train every day, and I wasn't doing that."

Marta retains the drive of an athlete—with some unusual specifics. She describes show jumping as "a thankless sport," simply because "most of the time, you lose." What it taught her was not only a lesson in humility but a sensitivity to others that has clearly been useful for her life in business. "The most special thing about it is that you're there with a living being," she explains. "Any athlete has to be fit, but in this case both you and the horse have to be in good shape. It's not a racket or a football—it's alive, and it depends on you."

Now Marta shares competition horses in Holland with the son of her original trainer, and she has a riding school in La Coruña that, among other things, offers therapy for children with disabilities. "I like not having lost touch with that world," she says. "It gave me so much for so long."



MAKING THE TEAM

Ortega Pérez and her husband, Carlos Torretta Echevarría (now Zara's head of communications), at their 2018 wedding in La Coruña.

Marta met Carlos Torretta Echevarría in January 2016 through a mutual friend. They all had dinner at Sant Ambroeus in the West Village—Carlos was working at a branch of the Elite modeling agency and had lived in New York for almost a decade. By April they were dating, and at the end of that year he moved back to his native Spain. They married in La Coruña two years later, and after a while Carlos—whom Marta says is "like a walking encyclopedia"—joined what he describes as "the biggest family business in the world."

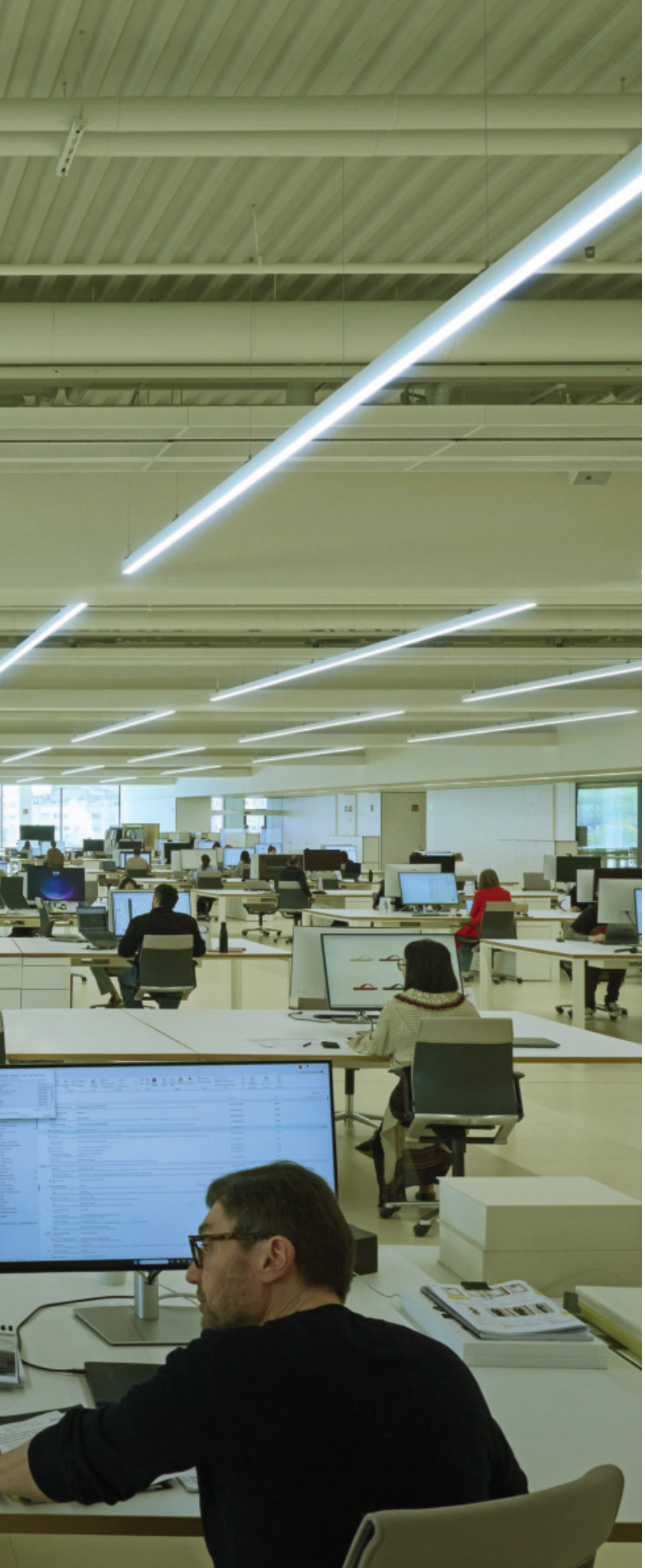
"They're a fantastic couple to spend time with," says Mulier, who enjoys summer holidays with them in Greece, eating and talking and waterskiing. "We're yin and yang," Carlos says affectionately. "I speak a lot, she speaks less. She's very organized and I'm more unorganized. You know, I'm sure it drives her crazy a million times a day, but in the end I think it works well. It's also very good for me," he adds, "to have someone like her who puts me on the right path." They still argue about the weather, Marta being fond of Galicia's British-style climes and Carlos being of a more Mediterranean bent.

Amancio, now 13, was joined by Matilda (6), Manuel (2)—and, most recently, a long-haired Jack Russell puppy. Their home in La Coruña—next door to Marta's parents'—has a calm atmosphere not unlike the one Zara has sought to create in The Apartment spaces within its stores; their nearby country house has a garden designed by the British landscape designer Tom Stuart-Smith. Each weekday Marta gets up at 6:45, goes to the gym ("normal training and some Pilates, nothing very exciting"), has breakfast with the kids, takes them to school, and drives to the office. In the evenings, she prefers reading to watching TV. Current favorite authors include

SASKIA LAWAKS.

ALL SYSTEMS GO
Ortega Pérez in the Inditex headquarters. When John Galliano visited the complex, he compared it to "a James Bond setup.... I was like, 'Wow—I've worked in ready-to-wear, darling, but this: This is incredible.' " In this story: hair, Damien Boissinot; makeup, Lucia Pica.

PRODUCED BY AL STUDIO; SET DESIGN: MARY HOWARD.



Ottessa Moshfegh and the Moldovan Romanian writer Tatiana Tibuleac. "I love a bookshop," she says. (She loves a stadium concert just as much, whether it's Bad Bunny or her friend Rosalía.)

It's not always easy to follow in your father's footsteps, especially when he's forged such a globe-spanning path, but Marta says she doesn't feel that pressure. "For me, it's a source of pride. I don't want to be like my father, because no one ever will be. I feel like I'm in a good moment of life," she explains: "I do a job I enjoy every day, I work with incredible people every day. To be able to do that in a city where I can be close to my family is an enormous privilege—not just my children but my extended family, who support me a huge amount."

David Sims's quadruple-height studio is a converted tram shed in North London, its cream-colored tiles reminiscent of those in old London Underground stations. On the day of the Zara shoot, one of the models, Karolina Spakowski, stands in a black slip dress against a gray infinity wall. The Bee Gees are playing through the speakers, and fans are gently blowing three different kinds of air toward her. Sims is shooting 12 pieces of clothing for The Item, a capsule that drops once a week, with everything overseen by Templer. Marta stands at the back of the studio in brown cargo pants and a knitted yellow top, hugging a leather-bound notebook. Two of her colleagues are beside her.

In November, Sims's work will form the latest photography exhibition at the Marta Ortega Pérez (MOP) Foundation in La Coruña. Photography, and fashion photography in particular, is something she's always loved. "In my head, I always thought I'd take photos," she tells me.

As a teenager, Marta would tag along with her mother to Zara shoots. "There was one in the Guggenheim in Bilbao," she remembers, "before it opened to the public. It was a Spanish photographer, and the models were Amber Valletta and Carolyn Murphy. I would have been 14 or 15—I went to watch them at work whenever they'd let me."

Though Marta's love of fashion was already clear then (she remembers traveling to New York with her mother and buying a pair of gray patent boots from Marc Jacobs), she now buys the kind of clothes that Zara is sometimes accused of emulating. (In 2012, Zara won a lawsuit from Christian Louboutin, allowing them to make red-soled shoes.) When I ask her about intellectual property, Marta offers a graceful response: "Fashion is a shared language," she says. "How you speak it is what marks the difference between some people and others. I have great respect for what designers do—I'm a client and admirer of many of them." She names people who have become friends—Mulier, Piccioli, and more. "Phoebe Philo, of course; Sarah Burton is doing incredible work. I've always been an absolute fan of Mrs. Prada. Willy Chavarria, Matthieu Blazy, Jonathan Anderson. The designer I've always admired the most is John Galliano, and I'm lucky enough to be working with him."

The respect is mutual. Piccioli describes Marta as "close to the fashion system" and offers a high compliment: She always, he says, spots the pieces of his that are "more for a connoisseur." "When you wear couture, you have to know why a black dress is couture while an embroidered dress is ready-to-wear," he explains. "You have to know that couture is about the hidden parts. It's not about what you show off. She really gets that point."

Whether fashion is one language or many, Marta is a perfectly placed translator. "Fast fashion, if I can call it that, wasn't welcomed with open arms initially," Sims points out. "And that might still be the case. But because Marta is such a CONTINUED ON PAGE 376

AHEAD OF THE BEAT

Photographed by
Norman Jean Roy

Two decades after he was heralded as the savior of classical music, conductor Gustavo Dudamel has lost none of his vim or vigor. Mattie Kahn catches up with him just before he takes the helm of the New York Philharmonic.

OFF BOOK
Dudamel, photographed backstage at David Geffen Hall, in a Dolce & Gabbana coat. Dunhill shirt and bow tie.
Sittings Editor: Michael Darlington.

The rain is unpleasant, but it seems fitting that the heavens have opened just as Gustavo Dudamel's car pulls up outside New York's historic United Palace theater. Sunshine is sweet and soundless. Storms can keep a beat.

It's spring, and the onetime wunderkind conductor—now a respectable 45—is still a few months from becoming the music and artistic director of the New York Philharmonic. Since the appointment was announced in 2023, he has been making a long and ecstatic first impression on his new metropolis. In April, at an annual fundraising gala, the philanthropist Barbara Tober spoke of Dudamel as "our gift from God." A few weeks later, a friend whose musical tastes lean more Shaboozey than Schubert posted a selfie from Lincoln Center for the Performing Arts, with Dudamel's signature curls bouncing in the background. At the end of a concert I attended this spring, women with hearing aids hooted and hollered. A man in a tux stomped his feet. After a requisite encore, hordes of people spilled out onto the plaza at Lincoln Center, buzzing over the ethereal arrangements of Igor Stravinsky.

Today, at the United Palace theater in Washington Heights, Dudamel is received by an audience of more composed staffers. "Hola, maestro," says a porter as Dudamel strides across the lobby. The Venezuelan-born conductor greets him in return. He has arrived to rehearse the first-ever joint performance by the 184-year-old New York Philharmonic and the 25-year-old Spanish Harlem Orchestra. Dudamel will hold the baton, combining classical and salsa music with the loving finesse of a musician raised on both. The conductor has long reveled in genre mash-ups that might otherwise sound like AI prompts. *What would a collaboration*

THE REMIX
Dudamel pays homage to the greats but is not afraid to let in fresh influences. Here he wears an Hermès shirt and Emporio Armani trousers. Rolex watch. In this story: grooming, Levi Monarch. Details, see In This Issue.

between Foo Fighters and Beethoven sound like? His repertoire at the Los Angeles Philharmonic, where he spent the past 17 years, included rousing renditions of Mahler and Philip Glass, as well as the *Star Wars* score. He has conducted at Coachella, voiced a character for the *Trolls World Tour* movie named Trollzart, and has inspired, it's said, the book and series *Mozart in the Jungle.* This past summer, he conducted the Muppets in a version of "Seven Nation Army" at the World Cup Halftime Show.

Later tonight, the two orchestras will perform Leonard Bernstein's *Times Square: 1944* ("New York, New York! / It's a helluva town!") and Brazilian composer Heitor Villa-Lobos's vivacious *Toccata.* Dudamel and I meet before the rehearsal in his dressing room—stocked with Brazil nuts and popcorn—where a clutch of assistants and flacks awaits his instruction. Still, he brushes off reports of Dudamania. "It's not only that I move beautifully my hands in front of an orchestra," he says, using the lilting syntax of someone who still translates from Spanish to English. "It's that we have to go deep, and they have to feel that it's honest."

Dudamel was born in Barquisimeto, one of Venezuela's bigger cities. His father, Oscar, is a classically trained trombonist and sometimes performs with him. (He'll be among the musicians at the United Palace.) His mother, Solange, sang. He picked up his first instrument as a preschooler, tapping out a rhythm on a güira, a percussion instrument, while his father was playing. "Who's that?" his father asked, hearing the beat.

He insists that he demonstrated no outsize talent then, but his interest was obvious, and it occurred to Oscar to enroll his son—now with a violin—in El Sistema, Venezuela's beloved and famed nationwide music program for children. His grandparents adored Gustavo, but they worried about his prospects. "Who will be able to stand all the noise in the house?" his grandfather once asked. A professional musician uncle was more encouraging, introducing him to the organ and the cuatro, a Latin string instrument. "He said, 'Look, son, you're going to play all of this music around the world,' " Dudamel recalls.

At El Sistema, intensive rehearsals were held over the weekend, and Dudamel made his closest friends in the program. One morning their conductor was late, so Dudamel stood in front and mimed the motions. His peers responded to him—he could command a room. El Sistema founder José Antonio Abreu took Dudamel on as a protégé, moving him to the first chair position in the violin section, then encouraging him to conduct. Abreu told his pupil he had duende, literally Spanish for "goblin" but more lyrically meant to describe a force animating great artists. "It is this kind of instinct," Dudamel recalls Abreu telling him. "That's duende."

Dudamel was just 23 when he emerged on the international circuit, winning a prestigious conducting competition in Germany and immediately radiating the kind of star power more often associated with pop princes and athletes than classical musicians. Orchestras from all over the world began to invite him to perform with them, appearances that earned both press and speculation about his future.

So lavish was the praise that Matías Tarnopolsky, now the president and CEO of the New York Philharmonic, then the orchestra's newly appointed artistic administrator, asked Dudamel if he could visit him in Caracas. "I got on a plane in 2006, within weeks of starting the job," Tarnopolsky recalls. Dudamel ferried him around in a Mustang, and the two established an easy connection—Dudamel playing folk music for the Buenos Aires–born Tarnopolsky that he hadn't heard since childhood while his passenger gripped the dashboard. ("I thought, Oh my God, I'm going to die here," Tarnopolsky remembers.) Dudamel made his debut in New York in 2007.

He performed in Chicago around the same time, and in the midst of the audition was whisked away after his first rehearsal on the private plane of then president of the Los Angeles Philharmonic Deborah Borda, who was eager to sign him. She flew him back to Chicago the following morning, with the unsuspecting orchestra having no idea he'd been hired out from under them. Dudamel officially joined the LA Phil at 28 and went on to hire almost half of its current musicians over the course of his tenure. The feel of the orchestra quickly shifted. He was loved "from day one," says Julie Andrews, who happens to be on the board. "They moved, and they swayed, which they had never done before. He freed them up."

One of the achievements that most heartens Dudamel, however, is his part in creating the Youth Orchestra of Los Angeles (YOLA), which he modeled on El Sistema. The group provides instruments and music education to children from all across Los Angeles, including from its poorer neighborhoods. Not long after it started, Jamie Bernstein, daughter of the iconic composer-conductor Leonard Bernstein, encountered a clip of Dudamel conducting YOLA's rendition of the mambo from *West Side Story.* "Some of them looked like they couldn't have been more than 14," she recalls of the musicians, "and they were just playing the daylights out of it. I thought, Wow, I've never seen anything like this before. And then I thought, Oh, it's the same vibe as my dad." She went to Venezuela to meet Dudamel, and the two have been friends ever since. Years ago she surprised him with one of her father's vests. "He just put it right on," she remembers.

Jamie is not the first to compare Dudamel to Bernstein, a titanic predecessor and the only other conductor whose name might reasonably appear CONTINUED ON PAGE 376

PRODUCED BY BOOM PRODUCTIONS INC.

Reaching

CON BRIO
Juilliard students and musicians—FROM LEFT, violinist Maude Cloutier, oboist Celia Wojcik, violinist Maya Kilburn, pianist Jude Giddens, cellist Noa Lia Mogle, and flautist Phoebe Rawn—find a moment to play around at Lincoln Center. Cloutier wears a **Loewe** top (loewe.com) and **Bode** shirt. Kilburn in **Chanel**; select Chanel boutiques. Giddens wears an **Auralee** suit; auralee.jp. Rawn in a **Lemaire** jacket (lemaire.fr) and **Tory Burch** top and skirt (toryburch.com).
Fashion Editor: Miyako Bellizzi.

Crescendo

Conductor Gustavo Dudamel's arrival at the New York Philharmonic has triggered a rhapsody in the city's classical-music scene—particularly among the young virtuosos of the Juilliard School, shot here with some of the Philharmonic's key players. Photographed by Theo Wenner.

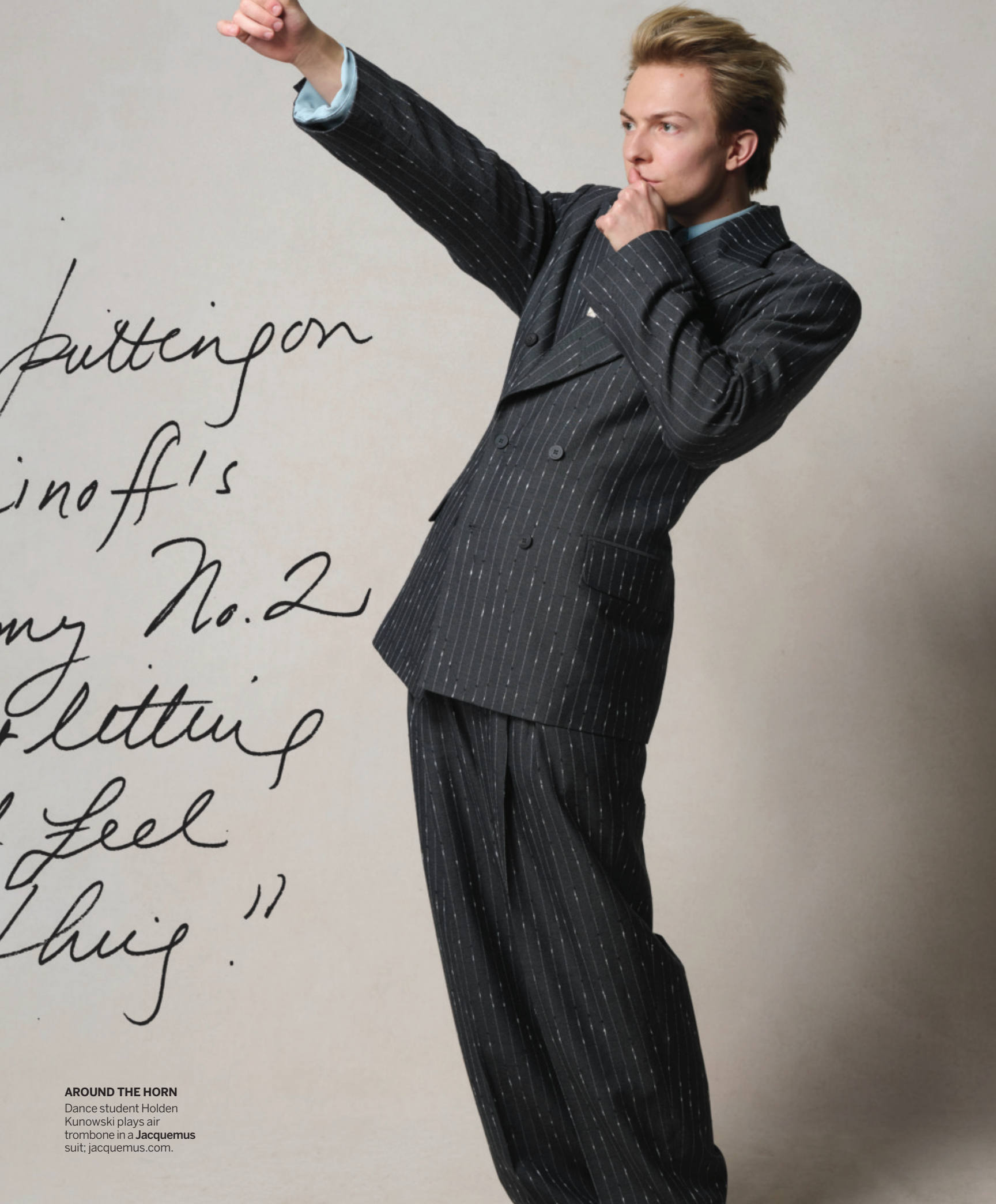
PITCH HITTERS

"When you have music, dance, and drama all working side by side, the experience is multidimensional," says Juilliard president Damian Woetzel. "It's a relationship of curiosity and opportunity." FROM LEFT: Dance major Arayah Lyte lounges in an **Alaïa** dress; maison-alaia.com. **Prounis** earrings. Giddens wears **Burc Akyol**; burcakyol.com.

STRING THEORY
Mogle tunes up in a **Loro Piana** top (loropiana .com) and **Alaïa** skirt (maison-alaia.com). **Tiffany & Co.** bracelet.

PUTTING ON AIR

"As the world becomes more modern, the deep human emotions that are the frameworks of classical music stay the same," says Wojcik, a senior at Juilliard. "I love putting on Rachmaninoff's *Symphony No. 2* and just letting myself feel everything." Wojcik in **The Row**; therow.com. **Tiffany & Co.** necklace.



AROUND THE HORN
Dance student Holden Kunowski plays air trombone in a **Jacquemus** suit; jacquemus.com.

MAKING OVERTURES
Cellist Ari Peraza-Webb wears a **Sacai** jacket; sacai.jp for similar styles. **Lié Studio** earrings.

LIVE TAKE
Jazz vocalist Ava Preston hits the high notes in a pink lace **Erdem** confection; erdem.com. **Sophie Buhai** earrings.

PUT A BOW ON IT

"Pieces of art created centuries ago communicate something that, somehow, people in 2026 can still relate to," Kilburn, a recent Juilliard grad, says. **Fendi** dress. **Tiffany & Co.** necklace and ring. Rawn in **Celine. Bvlgari** watch.

ON THE MOVE
Dancer Haley Beck—in a **Colleen Allen** top (colleenallen.com), **Max Mara** skirt (maxmara.com), and **Cartier** watch—feels the music.

PRETTY SUITE

ABOVE LEFT: Beck wears a **Khaite** dress; khaite.com. **Lié Studio** earrings. ABOVE RIGHT: Rawn's loose **Celine** dress and flowing golden waves offer a touch of nonchalance. **Lara Sonmez** ring. OPPOSITE: Wojcik—flanked by composition student Vincent Zhang and tuba player Lau Yeung Wong—wears a **Maison Margiela** dress; maisonmargiela.com.

PUT A PIN IN IT
New York Philharmonic cellist Claire Deokyong Kim wields her instrument in **Chanel**; select Chanel boutiques.

CODA
New York Philharmonic violist Leah Ferguson sticks out in a rich velvet **Fforme** dress; fforme.com. In this story: hair, Esther Langham; makeup, Aaron de Mey. Details, see In This Issue.

PRODUCED BY PARTNER FILMS. SET DESIGN: JULIA WAGNER.

All Wrapped Up

Because sometimes the coat *is* the outfit: Models Joan Smalls, Caroline Trentini, and Jessica Miller decamp to the bucolic British countryside in fall's finest outerwear. Photographed by Oliver Hadlee Pearch.

PLAYING THE FIELD

Smalls braces herself against the wind, keeping a tight lid on her shearling **Max Mara** coat and sweater; maxmara.com. **Louis Vuitton** cap.

Fashion Editor: Carlos Nazario.

GREEN AS GRASS
Smalls, Trentini, and Miller get cozy in the rolling hills. Smalls wears a **Victoria Beckham** coat and skirt. **Loro Piana** boots. Trentini bundles up in an **Akris** coat. Miller kicks back in a **Celine** trench and pants. OPPOSITE: It's a plaid world for Trentini, who mixes her patterned **Burberry** coats with pinstripe **Sacai** skirt-pants.

LOGGING OFF
Trentini makes herself at home in the crook of a felled tree. **Isabel Marant** coat and jacket; isabelmarant.com. **Ganni** trousers; ganni.com. **Hermès** boots; select Hermès boutiques. **Omega** watch; omega watches.com.

POP CULTURE
Amid the amber waves, Miller and Trentini stand out in bright primary hues with their cherry and mustard **Alaïa** coats from Pieter Mulier's final collection; maison-alaia.com.

CINCH BY CINCH
Trentini tightens her belt in a high-contrast **Hermès** coat; select Hermès boutiques.

REST ASSURED
Trentini finds a moment of peaceful solitude in a shearling **Louis Vuitton** coat and hat; select Louis Vuitton boutiques. **Pomellato** rings. **Omega** watch; omegawatches.com.

BRANCH DRESSING
Miller, clad in plaid, cuts a relaxed yet jaunty figure in an **Emporio Armani** coat and trousers; armani.com.

STICK WITH IT
Trentini stands tall in a sculptural **Loro Piana** jacket and matching trousers; loropiana.com.

KNOCK ON WOOD
Smalls communes with nature in a **Bottega Veneta** coat and skirt; bottegaveneta.com.

CARDINAL VIRTUES
No one's around for miles, but Miller is still keen to stand out in a **Michael Kors Collection** coat, dress, scarf, and gloves; michaelkors.com. In this story: hair, Louis Ghewy; makeup, Mel Arter. Details, see In This Issue.

PRODUCED BY PARTNER FILMS. SET DESIGN: ANDREW TOMLINSON.

327 North Rodeo Drive Beverly Hills

LOEWE

JUST KIDS

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 292

the media for a decade, found it all kind of wonderful.

"Everyone's being like, 'This is so sexy.' And I think that rocks," Gerber says. "We're clearly in one of those cycles right now where people are very, very, very thin. As someone who's been thin most of my life, I've always been compared against my mom—like, What's wrong with Kaia? I'm so jealous of my mom's body. I would have loved to be born with boobs and a butt. People have always commented on my body, which is hard because I'm not always ready to comment on my own body, you know? I've had disordered eating in my life. People are like, 'You look terrible,' and it doesn't exactly make you go, 'Oh, good. Let me get over this mental illness then!' Negativity has never saved someone's life."

Having had a string of famous, older boyfriends since she was a teenager, Gerber has grown a thick skin. She has been dating the actor and musician Lewis Pullman, the son of Bill Pullman, for nearly two years and calls it the healthiest and most adult relationship of her life. "There are so few things you get to protect as a famous person, and being defined by who you date when you're 18 is something I find challenging," she says. "I think I've been labeled in ways that are quite misogynistic: serial dater, slut, greedy. My mom is always like, Just don't make the same mistake twice. And I'm pretty good at not. I think the ultimate goal is that your relationship doesn't change you, that you're not code switching between relationship, friendship, professional life. I would love to always feel like me, and in this relationship I'm having the pleasure of doing that."

Gerber tends to speak with the wisdom of someone who has had to grow up both quickly and publicly. Right now she's reading, for the second time, *The Body Keeps the Score,* the Dutch American psychiatrist Bessel van der Kolk's exploration of the relationship between trauma and attachment. Gerber volunteers at a trauma center where she hopes to be a thoughtful and informed presence rather than, as she puts it, "a shiny distraction." She wishes she could be synonymous with her work, a trick some screen stars, such as her idol Gena Rowlands, managed. "To me that's the ultimate flex. To me Mark Rylance is one of the greatest actors of all time, and he shows up at Cannes wearing, like, sandals and cargo shorts. I have sort of succumbed to the fact that that will never be in the cards for me."

For a person who has always felt insecure—a fact she is reluctant to acknowledge because she knows that pretty people don't get much sympathy for their soft spots—she has never been more comfortable looking at herself in the mirror. Gerber and Gere watched the pilot of *The Shards* together: fun for her, harrowing for him. ("I can't watch myself," he says. "It's a whole thing.") They have talked about what to expect from a knives-out viewing public that might think, Here is peak nepo baby.

"I've only ever been a nepo baby, and I've only ever benefited in my career from it," Gerber says. "But I also find myself doing it to other nepo babies, thinking, like, Okay, show me why you deserve this job. I said to Homer—because the concept is daunting to him, having lived as an adult so far without that perception, whereas I sort of went through it when I wasn't fully sentient—I said to him, 'Homer, unfortunately with this show, it's not like you're just any unknown actor and people will judge you as an unknown actor. But what that's done for me is make me want to work harder.' "

Gere has a stutter, which he has learned to mask following years of speech therapy in middle school and a decade of practice since then. In that premonitory moment when he feels he is about to get stuck on a word, he pivots. "What I do is, I'll change the word at the last minute," he explains, "so if I'm going to stutter on *rock,* I'll switch it to *stone.* I'm constantly playing a game of cat and mouse with my own mind." Despite the wish for a quiet life, for the monastery or the mountaintop, like Robert Mallory, Gere seems to have a talent for finding himself in the center of the image. He would never call it star quality, though others might.

"I'm a very self-critical guy who would like to believe that my career's going well for all the wrong reasons," he says. "But the more success I have, the harder it becomes to believe that. I think doubting yourself a little bit is very healthy, no matter how good you are. At anything. You should always be a little nervous if you're doing something worthwhile." □

ARYNA UNCHAINED

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 318

She says that her mother told her that when she was a toddler, she would fall on the floor and bang her head until she got what she wanted. She was always fiery, it seems, and she recalls with some embarrassment the verbal firebombs she used to hurl at her parents. "I was very much a Taurus," she explains. "Like, if I see a goal, I need to get it, and there is no other way. This is part of my personality that can drive me crazy, but it can also drive me into that real fight mode and help me play with passion. It's two sides of the medal."

Sabalenka arrived at a moment when the so-called Big Babe era of women's tennis—a term coined by the sports journalist and former pro Mary Carillo to describe the power games of players such as Lindsay Davenport, Mary Pierce, and ultimately the Williams sisters—was in quiescence. Angelique Kerber, Simona Halep, and Ashleigh Barty—scrappier athletes with more versatile, all-court games—started winning majors, but then Sabalenka came in with her six-foot frame and booming ground strokes. With an intense on-court presence, that quick temper, and a natural imperiousness, she seemed, somehow, more Serena than Serena. Smirks and eye rolls, grunts that led chair umpires to accuse her of hindering play, smashed rackets, and tense exchanges with officials have marked her tenure on tour—and, for a while, her short fuse appeared to be undermining her results. Sabalenka began to develop a reputation for painful losses in high-stakes matches. She has won four Grand Slam finals—and lost four Grand Slam finals. "I was, like, under zero control," she says. "I could lead the match, then be super crazy and let it go. I knew that I had a problem."

Though she worked with a psychologist from the ages of 18 to 24—a transformative experience that endowed her with self-regulation techniques and, above all, a way of talking herself through fervid moments—Sabalenka would be the first to describe herself as a work in progress. While she was ranked number one for all 52 weeks of 2025, it was also a season studded with headline-grabbing incidents. In the final of the Australian Open in January, she could be seen smashing her racket on court just before the winner's trophy was presented to Madison Keys. Following her loss to Coco Gauff in the final of the French Open in June, Sabalenka told reporters that the American "won the match not because she played incredible, just because I made all of those mistakes from… easy balls." In October, at the Wuhan Open, on her way to losing a semifinal match to Jessica Pegula, she hurled her racket in frustration. It bounced up and nearly hit a ball kid, leading to a warning for "racket abuse" by the chair umpire.

Her pique has not been confined to defeats. In Miami this March, during the final that she went on to win over Gauff, a spectator shouted "out!" in the middle of a point, earning an admonition from the umpire. Sabalenka, frustrated, yelled "shut up!" into the crowd and received an obscenity warning: call and response in reverse. During the trophy presentation, she praised her opponent and then looked into the crowd and said, "Where you are, that lady that yelled, that hoped for the out? I shouldn't have been that rude—but come on, you cannot do that. So let's agree that we both were wrong. Sorry."

There has long been more than a whiff of a double standard when it comes to expressed emotion in women's tennis, and anachronistic notions about what is "ladylike" persist in fan forums and even among some commentators. (Serena Williams faced similar criticisms—for the volume of her shrieks, for the shape of her body, for her temper and her tone in defeat.) The internet has also taken a malevolent pleasure in imagining feuds between women players. Sabalenka and Gauff were quick to quell this fantasy when they teamed up for a TikTok video, dancing together in their tennis whites on Wimbledon's Centre Court, a few weeks after the French Open controversy. By then, Sabalenka had already publicly apologized to Gauff for what had occurred in that press conference. To her credit, she excels at something Williams never mastered: the public mea culpa. And for every spectator whom she alienates, there is another who recognizes a prodigal daughter in those apologies and thinks, Here, among the famous and false, is a genuine human being.

Sabalenka is matter-of-fact about it all. "When you're in the top five and you're winning Grand Slams," she says, by way of explanation, "it's not okay to be okay with losing. That's my mentality."

Sabalenka met her best friend on the tour, Paula Badosa, at an exhibition match before the Indian Wells tournament in 2022. Known

collectively by fans as Sabadosa, they have celebrated their shared love of dancing in numerous TikTok videos. "I've seen a big change in her," Badosa says. "Three or four years ago, it was tougher for her to control her emotions. Aryna is always going to be a very intense person on-court. But she's also really sensitive. She has a big, big heart. She jokes that she's a tiger, and she has that tiger tattoo on her arm. But I always say off the court she's a teddy bear. She's very affectionate, and she takes care of her people."

Though she has been accused of trying to apologize her way out of her peccadilloes, to spend time with Sabalenka is to experience the chasm between player and person. Face-to-face, she is light, relaxed, and self-deprecating, unguarded and reflective. "You have to accept that you've been wrong," she says, then laughs. "And I've been wrong so many times." But she pushes back against the idea that a fiery temper is definitionally bad. In fact, she *believes* in it. "When I was young, I would get really pissed with myself for getting emotional. Now I understand that it's okay to throw the racket. It's okay to yell something. It's okay to go nuts if you feel like you're holding too much in. Sometimes you just need to let it go. Yeah, sometimes it looks ugly and terrible, but I need it in order to keep my head in it."

Sabalenka's tremendous popularity suggests that fans agree with her that the ugly and terrible can make for thrilling tennis. She trails only Gauff in earnings from brand endorsements, with sponsorships that include Nike, the watchmaker Audemars Piguet, and, as of this January, Gucci. The venerable Italian house chooses its brand ambassadors carefully; in tennis, that has meant only Sabalenka and the men's number one, Jannik Sinner. In March, she was part of an especially interesting front row at Gucci's Milan Fashion Week show that included Shawn Mendes, Romeo Beckham, Donatella Versace, and the boyish Formula 1 driver Kimi Antonelli. Intensity, authenticity, humor, glamour—Sabalenka's off-court success proves that these are as valuable as a great first serve.

"People know when you're being your true self," says Frangulis, her fiancé. "There's always going to be something tricky in a match, because Aryna's going to say what she feels. And she's going to do the same on Instagram and TikTok. That makes her special. But I've always told her that, to stay composed, she has to try to attach herself to the facts, to what is actually happening, and not to what's coming to her mind. It's not about erasing those emotions. It's about using them in her favor—making it one of her superpowers instead of her kryptonite."

Big personalities have big admirers and big detractors, and Sabalenka is aware that she is not everyone's favorite flavor. That's okay. "With a lot of love and a lot of attention and a lot of success, there's always gonna be people who judge you," she says. "They judge your look, they judge your grunting, your nationality, even your private life, your choices."

Perhaps the most stinging vitriol has surrounded her Belarusian identity in the wake of the war in Ukraine. Since its start, in 2022, Belarus has been Russia's key ally and a launching pad for its incursions. Some fellow players have accused Sabalenka of outright supporting the war; others of not using her platform to condemn it more vigorously. Sabalenka has been clear that she does not support the war, or any war, and also that sport ought to transcend politics in its fundamental commitment to connection rather than division, competition rather than conflict.

"Not shaking hands—I respect that position," she says, referring to the decision by some players, including the Ukrainian Elina Svitolina, not to shake hands at the net after matches with Russian and Belarusian athletes. "I know it's not personal. They're sending a message. But it was tough, the amount of hate I was receiving from people on tour. One coach went nuts on me, saying that I'm the one who's throwing the bombs. It's obvious that I want peace for everyone. I don't want this war to happen. But I also think that sport is a platform and a place where we can come together, not fight against each other as if we're having our own war. Get together, be together, show peace. For so long, Ukrainians and Belarusians were like brothers and sisters. We're the same. We're all tied close together. And now there's a huge wall between us, and I don't know if it's ever going away."

In 2019, when Sabalenka was 21, her father died suddenly of meningitis. It was November, the offseason, and she was training in Minsk. As she remembers it, on the day he fell ill, her mother called an ambulance, but the medics lowered his fever and kept him home. She called another ambulance the next day, with the same result. "I was like, let me fucking carry him to the hospital myself if the ambulance isn't taking him," Sabalenka recalls. "They took him on the third day, and it was too late. It was even harder for my mom. And I didn't realize until later how much my sister suffered. We were both daddy's little girls."

Though she has gotten closer to her mother in recent years, her father had been the central pillar of her support system. She called him whenever she was struggling personally or professionally, and his words had a way of setting things right. When he died, only training took her mind off her grief. "People say that time helps, but in some ways I struggle more now because I know how much fun my dad would be having with my success," she says. "Nowadays my fiancé will find me crying in bed in the evening because I'm watching Reels and there's something about a father, or old times. The most sensitive videos for me are when I see people posting a family reaction to their kid athlete winning something, and I just imagine how my dad would react to me. There are so many fathers on tour, and when I see a healthy relationship and a proud dad, I think, Girl, just enjoy it, because you never know what's coming. You're so lucky."

Not long before her father died, Sabalenka hired Jason Stacy as her fitness trainer. The title vastly underestimates his role on a team that is especially tightly knit, in a sport whose top players often describe their traveling teams as families. To Sabalenka, Stacy is, she says, "like a father." The longest-serving member of a unit that spends 330 days of the year together and its elder statesman (he is just a bit older than Sabalenka's father would be if he were alive), Stacy has been instrumental in her recovery from losses on and off the court. "I always tell her, don't fight it, and don't feed it," he says of those losses. Stacy, who was homeless as a teenager before a transformative introduction to martial arts, has taught Sabalenka some of the fundamental precepts of Zen Buddhism. These include *Zanshin,* a relaxed awareness; *Mushin,* mental clarity; and *Tomaranu Kokoro,* a spirit that is always moving. "Aryna's learned how emotions are information. These days she can take that information and process it better. It's the progression from fighter to warrior. She was that young fighter, running off adrenaline. Warriors are calmer. They can zoom out and then zoom back in and refocus on the right thing."

Sabalenka suffered another loss in March 2024, when her ex-boyfriend, the hockey player Konstantin Koltsov, died by apparent suicide in Miami. She was on the practice courts in Miami, the closest thing Sabalenka has to a home base, when police approached her with the news. "I was fighting with the cop—like, I couldn't accept it," she remembers. Again Sabalenka tried to immerse herself in her game. She began playing in the Miami Open days later but lost in the third round, smashing her racket and canceling her press conference.

It was around this time that Frangulis and Sabalenka were becoming a couple. They had first met the previous fall, in Dubai, when she signed a sponsorship deal with Oakberry. By the time they had dinner the next spring in Indian Wells, Frangulis says, they were somewhere "in between" business colleagues and romantic partners. They are both citizens of the world: The headquarters of Frangulis's company is in Miami and the back office in São Paulo, while his main European office is in Madrid. Dating a professional athlete has its logistical complexities, but Frangulis says that nowadays he bases his travel around hers, and that works for them both.

On the day we speak, he has just returned to Rome from Corsica, where he watched French soccer club Le Mans FC, of which he is a part owner, play its last match of the season. The previous morning, Sabalenka suffered a surprise defeat in her third-round match at the Italian Open. "Aryna is very upset," he says. "For me, it's a matter of being around but also giving her the space to get her thinking straight. She's a killer, she's the best, but sometimes it takes her 24 hours to remember that. My goal is to do whatever she's doing, but if she wants to spend the whole day in her hotel room, I tell her we can't just stay here as if someone has died. So tonight, we're going out for some pasta."

Like many athletes, Sabalenka has certain rituals at every tournament. In Rome, one of those is the amatriciana at Taverna Trilussa in Trastevere, where she has been known to arrive by Lime scooter for dinner with her team. When life is rich outside the arena, it seems, the losses sting less.

This year's clay and grass court seasons brought a string of frustrating defeats, including

at the French Open and Wimbledon. Following the French, she went to Vienna, had some great meals, wandered through some art galleries, and did her best to be something other than a tennis player for a few days. After Wimbledon, she and Frangulis flew to Mykonos, where they hit the beach clubs and spent time on a boat. Sabalenka is sanguine and practical about the latest rough patch. "I'm not really trying to chase that feeling of confidence, which goes up and goes down," she tells me by phone from Europe. "It's more important to believe in yourself and your game every time you get on the court…. And this time I think I handled myself much better, even when things were going completely not the way I wanted."

There is a wedding to plan—Greece, summer of 2027, she's thinking. When the subject of marriage comes up, Sabalenka is probably not the first fiancée to peer down at her engagement ring with a look of wonder that life's cruel show can't overcloud.

"I see a little bit of my father in him, and I absolutely love it," she says of Frangulis. "You know, I would tell him, 'I'm a big girl, and my hand is big, and a small ring would look very… small.'" Fortunately, there is no rule against big, blinding baubles on the tennis court—even if they might lead to another hindrance call. "That's the whole idea—especially if you're playing a night match, and the lights are hitting it. Then it's, like, right in their eyes." □

INSIDE DEMNA'S GUCCIVERSE

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 326

knew the movie, you know?" Demna tells me. "I knew Alessandro, and I knew Tom Ford from fashion TV when I was, like, 13…but to understand the brand, I had to know what Gucci stood for outside of those three things." Over the weeks that followed, he made visits to the Gucci archive, in Florence, with espionage-like cover. "I saw the whole world," he says. "Homeware. Chairs. Umbrellas. A roulette wheel. And on top of that, the most incredible collections." He shrugs. "I was seduced."

Demna proposed to Bellettini that he compile a presentation in which to assemble his thoughts. "I need to convince you and myself that we can do this," she recalls him saying. It was the holidays, and he and Gomez were in Los Angeles. "On the day I finished," Demna says, "I showed it to my husband.'" (Demna sometimes refers to Gomez as his "fashion therapist.")

"My husband looked and was like, 'It gives me a FOMO feeling—I want to *be* that or I want to *have* it,'" Demna recalls. That frame clicked. "I was like, *that's* what my vision of Gucci is—creating this FOMO," he says. "The chic, the elegance, the Italian-ness of it. The dolce vita, but in a nonchalant way. There's a bit of humor to it, but it's not sarcastic. It's a fun thing, quite punk, in a way—like, 'I like myself, and I don't care what other people think.' There's something daring about it—it's flamboyant. It's confident. You know who you are."

The Los Angeles fires started that night. Demna left with nothing but his passport and his laptop: He had not backed up his presentation. "I sent it to Kering, and I was like: This is my vision…. And if they don't like it, I might as well know that now."

But Bellettini understood what he put forward: a freedom possible only in a house whose history was rich in product. "What he was explaining as a liberation was the fact that the brand doesn't come from a couture maison," she recalls. "There isn't a Cristóbal Balenciaga, an Yves Saint Laurent, a Christian Dior, to whom you're always going to be compared." When Demna presented his plan to François-Henri Pinault, the chairman of Kering, he was pelted with questions. "François-Henri wanted to be *sure*," Bellettini says. "And Demna was so precise in his answers that he was like, 'Okay, done.'"

In general, Demna's creative day starts slowly—a self-protective nest of discipline which he says he learned from Marc Jacobs, for whom he worked at Louis Vuitton more than a decade ago. In Milan, he takes the morning for himself. He has coffee and a smoothie with his husband. He meditates. He cuddles his two Chihuahuas and takes them walking with Gomez. "We talk about stuff that isn't fashion," he says. "I want to have this moment which is about my family, my husband, and me. And us as a couple. And our life."

At noon, he reports for work at the office, from which point he is usually scheduled straight through to 8 p.m. He rarely takes more than a 15-minute break. "It's intense, but I love it, because when I'm in the flow of working, I'm quite fast in making decisions," he says. "We manage a lot for a brand this size in one day." In the evening, he returns home and cooks dinner with Gomez—or, rather, alongside Gomez, who maintains a different diet. ("He's gluten-free. I'm vegan," Demna says. "Sometimes it overlaps, but"—he smiles—"it's hard to be gluten-free in Italy.") In Los Angeles they go out for dinner most nights, but in Milan this "ritual," as Demna calls it, is their life.

"We cook, we watch stand-up comedy on YouTube, listen to music," he says. They go out for dinner once a week at most, and usually on the weekend, after walking through the city. "I don't really have a lot of social life in Milan," he says. "I'm always going to be this rebellious person, but now I live this Gucci life professionally." His rebellion, in the Gucci way, has taken on bourgeois hues.

We are drinking ginger-lemon kombucha at a banquette table in the Campbell Bar in New York's Grand Central Station. Demna is in the middle of a two-week stay in New York; after preparing two looks for the Met Gala, he is now preparing for his larger errand in town. In a few days' time, Gucci will show its cruise collection in the center of Times Square, and Demna has been roaming the city for research and inspiration.

"I'll go to vintage stores, bookstores. See some art, get some cultural impact," he says. The process is about both gathering images as references for his collections and buying vintage pieces to use as physical canvases, "raw material" that he can cut and pin. "It's very hard sometimes to start making a jacket from scratch, especially when it comes to tailoring and shapes," he explains. "I need to have material that has good details and good proportions that I can cut and Frankenstein into the shapes I want to get to."

Shape has been extensively on Demna's mind as he works on his September collection. After taking his deliberate process of understanding Gucci stage by stage—starting with the fundamentals of La Famiglia and progressing to the sexy Fordian club style of his first Milan show—he feels that he is ready to present a Gucci that draws on the history of the house but is his. In fashion terms, this means coming out with new silhouettes: particular configurations of form, proportion, and mood, which, like the boxy Chanel jacket or the Dior hourglass of a dress, will be recognizable as the signature of his vision for the brand.

"Personally, I'm in *need* of a defined Gucci silhouette, and in September I will dare myself to show it," he says, and signals for a second kombucha. "It's about centimeters, it really is," he says. "It's about proportion. And I want to do something that also I haven't done before, which"—he smiles—"limits the possibilities."

He started with the mood: "What is the feeling I want to give so a person can be like, 'I feel Gucci'?" In consultation with Gomez, acting as his fashion therapist, he began listing all the qualities that he wanted his new Gucci silhouette to project. Facing the blank page on his laptop one day, with his deadlines for the September runway drawing ever nearer, he wrote:

Sharp, Confident, Chic, Bold, Rich, Eccentric, Hot, Sexy, Cool.

"*Sharp* as in not wobbly, not round: There is no cocoon shape at Gucci," he explains. "*Sexy* and *hot:* They're not the same. You can be completely covered and feel hot, but you can't be sexy. For sexy, you need to show some body. Gucci needs to have both."

One by one, he worked through his words, using them to define what the silhouette was and wasn't. In the spring, he went to one of his favorite vintage men's tailoring shops, in Rome. "It has the most meticulous selection of jackets and coats in Italian men's tailoring—I half-emptied the store," he says. "We're using those pieces when I work the silhouette, in defining the shoulder line and the sleeve shape."

A few days later, I meet Demna in the 23rd Street studio where he is holding fittings for the New York show. The show's fashion concept expresses his mercantile turn. "I call it GucciCore," he tells me. "Like hard-core, but also the essence, the base, of the aesthetic"—in other words, "staples" that customers can reliably find in a Gucci shop.

"For example, this is a very important piece for me," he says, pulling from the rack a red women's double-breasted jacket, his version of the classic peacoat. "I was afraid to work on it, because I don't like peacoats: How could I make one that I really liked?" The answer to the question became a kind of key: If he could make a Gucci peacoat that he loved ("It's the fit, the proportions of the collar, the size and positioning of the buttons, the length"), then he could extend his point of view across worlds of merchandise.

The other key—and perhaps his greatest, if quietest, innovation at Gucci to date—concerned sizing. Traditionally, fashion is tailored to tall runway models and then graded up or down into standard sizes, often losing the proportional relationships crucial to a fit. "It doesn't consider the body type," Demna says. "If someone is shorter and more muscled, he's going to look like a dork." At Gucci, he is developing a wholly new sizing system so that the integrity of a look will hold whether you're tall and lean or short and thick. In the meantime, many cruise collection pieces exist in three different fits: a small, a medium, and what might be called a Demna fit—the baggy proportions that he himself would buy.

During fittings, Demna perches at a table at one end of the studio. An assistant brings him an energy bar and a bowl of nuts. A tall male model appears in a jacket, sunglasses, and flowing black pants.

"I'm not sure about this one," Demna says. He takes off the sunglasses, then walks over to a rack of pieces, assessing alternatives, and eventually emerges on a long coat. The problem with the jacket, he explains, was that it looked somehow implausible. "That's my big thing—to find the authenticity."

The night of the show is clear and cool: a New York City spring caught in the hourglass of Times Square. Smoke is piped in from the street corners, giving the Midtown canyons an eerie feel. By 8:10 p.m., guests have begun to arrive on Gucci's walled-off gray carpet. "Being at Gucci, he can dream as big as he wants, right?" Kardashian tells me. "He can say 'I want a show in Times Square' and pull it off."

Demna is with Gomez in a sushi restaurant on 47th Street that has been commandeered as the show's backstage. In one hand, he holds a Starbucks cup; in the other, a big red apple, as if in a nod to the city. The floor is marked with lineup tape for the models, and large screens near the entrance track street footage from cameras and drones. Demna draws close and peers at the footage in wonder for a moment and then, with Gomez, heads out into the cool air of the square.

Imaginary Gucci advertisements are playing across nearly 50 billboard-size screens and more than two dozen more at sidewalk level. Every celebrity arrival—from Mariah Carey in a crisp white Gucci coat to Lindsay Lohan in a black leather ensemble, Playboi Carti in shiny python trousers to EsDeeKid in a shimmering black jacket and baggy silver jeans (and his signature balaclava)—garners cheers from onlookers gathered on sidewalks and street corners. At a few minutes past nine, the screens all dim. Charlie Jones, again in the first look—this time bearing an apple in a deceptively simple black suit—traces a path through the crowd.

In the wee hours of the previous night, when Times Square was as quiet and as empty as it would ever be, the Gucci crew had assembled for their only rehearsal. Everybody wore earphones so as not to project the music, curated by Gomez, through the square. Now, with full sound and all 50 big screens tracing the runway movement with nervy panoptic attention, the effect is haunting. Suits of various power hues come down the runway. The red peacoat appears paired with black pants. There are bikers in leather, Venuses in shearling. Tom Brady swaggers in an asymmetric black jacket and matching trousers in leather. (For all the show's diversity in age and aspect, it continues to center on slender or gym-built bodies.) When Paris Hilton appears with a black fur-like coat slung over the shoulder of a sunflower yellow Gucci-patterned summer dress with a high lavallière neck—hot, not sexy—every phone in the audience seems to lift up.

For much of his career, Demna was known for shows that built toward an unsettled climax, but the effect here is the opposite. The sequence culminates as Cindy Crawford, at 60, dressed in a high shoulder-less dress of long black feathers, takes the final walk, as slowly and as grandly as *la passeggiata*. For a long, dilated moment, the entirety of Times Square is silent, as if holding its breath.

Later that night, the party reconvenes at the Gucci Mansion, a property with a courtyard on Madison Avenue reimagined as a center of the Gucci life across time. A jazz singer and quartet on the first floor scat-sings "It's De-Lovely." In a private karaoke room upstairs, guests are trying their luck at 50 Cent's "P.I.M.P." The basement is a billiards lounge in red—red carpet, red curtains, red walls. A fortune teller in a hideaway reads the future by lamplight.

Demna arrives after midnight and settles into the courtyard, dense with smokers and guests taking the night air. He is surrounded by well-wishers and in an expansive mood. "I'm relieved that this is done, because it was very complex," he says, still clutching his Starbucks cup—as if the evening, carried by its Gucci momentum, has borne him ceaselessly along. "But a lot of people told me that it was 12 minutes of forgetting about whatever they were thinking before." He smiles. "I love that." □

THE MATRIARCH

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 328

of parenting a child through crisis. Her own parents—her American mother, Judith (known to listeners of Louis-Dreyfus's podcast, *Wiser Than Me*), and her French father, Gérard—divorced when she was young. Louis-Dreyfus understands, from both sides, how family shapes us, and she knows the stakes in the play couldn't be higher. Brooke's memoir "is like a murder," she tells me. "Polly sees it as a killing of what they have."

Fifteen years after its premiere at Lincoln Center, *Other Desert Cities* feels ever more acutely urgent. Its setting is 2004 America, a country still raw from the September 11 attacks and only one year into the Iraq War. References to anthrax, Donald Rumsfeld, and al-Qaida are peppered throughout like shrapnel. The fault lines that would fracture our politics had not fully formed; the Wyeths' mainstream conservatism would soon have little place in the culture. This was also the period before smartphones and social media—and the last moment when the code of silence on which Polly depends could be credibly maintained.

"All of the extraordinary seeds of that national tragedy are in this play," says Hickey. "But in an incredibly funny, familial way."

When assembling the cast, Hickey needed actors who could bring the world of more than two decades ago into the present. The result? "The Knicks lineup," he says. Joining Louis-Dreyfus are Ed Harris as Lyman, Allison Janney as Silda, Lily Rabe as Brooke, and, as Trip, Joe Keery (from *Stranger Things,* and also a popular musician performing under the stage name Djo).

"They recognize what a team sport this play is," Hickey says. That's also a quality Louis-Dreyfus recognized: that the play is an ensemble of vividly written characters, each deeply flawed and desperately human.

By the time Louis-Dreyfus and I meet, the cast has had two read-throughs—one before she had taken the part. What Hickey heard from her—warmth fused with steel, acerbic humor combined with a deep well of grief—told him everything he needed to know. He said, "Julia, my only note is: Say yes. Say yes. Jump into this."

Ed Harris speaks to me from Fort Worth, where he is on a break from shooting the Paramount+ show *Dutton Ranch.* It's been over six years since he last appeared on Broadway as Atticus Finch in *To Kill a Mockingbird,* and he's ready for a return. "I need it for my sanity," he notes dryly.

What he loves about theater is the purity. "You come to the theater, you prepare, you do the show, and you go home. You're not sitting around for 12 hours to be in front of the camera for two minutes." Harris will bring an old-world masculine reticence to Lyman, whose wounds run deeper than they appear. "I think it's perhaps more difficult for him in a way than it is for Polly," he says. "I think it really affected him very deeply."

Meanwhile, Allison Janney's character, Silda, is a train wreck with a devastating quip. When we speak, Janney is in Italy, shooting the Netflix series *The Diplomat.* ("I had to buy another suitcase because I went a little crazy with the shopping here," she says.) Janney has been close friends with Hickey, who is also an actor, for 30 years—they last appeared onstage together in *Six Degrees of Separation,* playing husband and wife—and has long known Baitz, who wrote for *The West Wing,* on which she appeared for seven seasons.

Silda, with her outspokenness and history of addiction, has a different operating system than Polly—her intelligence is less controlling, more observational. Silda joins a long line of indelible Janney characters who use wit as a kind of scrutiny. "I take on these strong, powerful women and just have fun with them. This is heaven to me."

The play asks if family members can ever overcome old roles. Hickey mentions that he recently saw Joe Mantello's stunning new production of *Death of a Salesman* and recognized the shared DNA. "All the great family plays are the same," he says. "They're all *A Long Day's Journey Into Night.* They ask, Who is my dad? Who is my mom? And the answer: I'll never really know."

Louis-Dreyfus puts this idea even more intimately. "Siblings have their own very isolated experience: 'You have different parents than I have,'" she says. "This is true in my family—and I say this as somebody with a lot of sisters. My husband's family has lots of siblings. Our two kids have their own experience of us as parents."

Before our lunch, she toured the Hudson Theater for the first time, standing on the stage, taking its measure. "It's a great theater because it is intimate," she says. "People aren't super far away. It feels personal." The intimacy is by design. The Wyeth family's midcentury-modern Palm Springs house is a character itself. Scott Pask, the show's designer and a great student of the era, is approaching the set like a boxing ring: This feels appropriate for a family whose native language is the verbal spar—the characters land their punches, then retreat.

The boxing ring metaphor appeals to Janney too: "We all take our rounds. 'Ding, ding, ding—I'm down for the count on that exchange.'"

Until *Other Desert Cities* opens this fall, the cast, and the Wyeths, will be trying to find each other, learning how to spar, rehearsing their entrances and exits. In a play about memory, truth, storytelling, and what we choose to preserve, Janney's instinct is straightforwardly human. "I cherish them," she says of her fellow actors. "And I swear to God—to my mother—this time I will journal every day, because I want to remember it." □

FAMILY TIES

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 337

charismatic leader, she creates something that could be seen as harmonious with the institutional houses."

"For sure," says Piccioli, "she is the future."

Fast fashion is not a term Marta uses. She prefers *flexible.* Almost everything Zara makes travels through its distribution centers in La Coruña, which allows them to be agile. "I don't think the company would be what it is if we hadn't stayed in La Coruña," Marta says. Having spawned an industry built on speed, the company's leaders say they now aim to be at the forefront of resolving some of its repercussions. Marta tells me that Inditex is committed to improving the social and environmental conditions of its workers, and she is keen to lead the charge on sustainability and aim for net-zero emissions by 2040. Hakan Karaosman, an expert on social sustainability in fashion supply chains, points out that while Inditex is currently stronger on its water footprint than it is on social issues, it is "really innovative with supply chain design, because they established nearshoring."

"Our business is very demand-oriented," Marta says. "The key is to keep stock levels very low and leftovers to a minimum. There are less than 1 percent unsold products—we don't do big shipments that don't work and that we have to store in a warehouse. Even if others want to define it as fast fashion, our business model itself may be the most sustainable thing we have." In 2022 they launched Zara Pre-owned, a considered platform that makes it easy for you to repair, resell, or donate your Zara clothes.

Galliano, who calls his two-year project for Zara a "reauthoring" of garments from its archive, admits that his initial reaction, when Marta asked if he might work with Zara, was "No way." His reservations were probably "the same as everyone's," he guesses, based on "ill-formed or secondhand news." By the time he'd done the tour of Inditex and seen the gallery of sustainable fabrics, he'd changed his view. "There's a couple of fabrics that every couturier uses—silk chiffon, organza. They said, 'Oh no, you can't use that—they're highly flammable. Now, you *can* use this one.' They're so on it."

Marta opened her foundation by accident. "Peter Lindbergh was our wedding photographer and a personal friend," she says. "He had curated an exhibition to be shown in Düsseldorf, and he never got to see it. [Lindbergh died in 2019.] When I saw that they were due to open the show there, I spoke to his son Ben and said that I'd love to do an exhibition of Peter's work in La Coruña. It was all for Peter."

She found a cement silo in La Coruña's port that had been empty for 20 years and commissioned a local architect, Elsa Urquijo, to transform it. Now it houses an elegant fountain looking out to the sea, a sequence of monumental exhibition spaces, and an extraordinary spiral-shaped bookshop. The foundation produces a catalog under the MOP imprint for every exhibition—the day I went it was Annie Leibovitz; that was followed by Paolo Roversi—they host talks and book signings, and they give scholarships to four Galician photography students every year to enable them to study abroad.

In this way, Marta, ever proud of the city and the region where she grew up, has made La Coruña and Galicia something of a destination. But what strikes me most is how personal all of this is to her: fashion, photography, family, friends. She tells me about a day she spent in Paris with Lindbergh and the Lanvin designer Alber Elbaz, both now departed. "I have a photo of that day that I think of with a lot of affection," she says.

"We always talk about fashion as if it were something frivolous, but I think it's very human," Marta suggests. "Fashion is present in the lives of millions of people every day. It's how we present ourselves to the world. It sustains a lot of creativity and requires a lot of sensitivity. And it can be wonderful if we do it well." □

AHEAD OF THE BEAT

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 341

as a *Jeopardy!* clue. Bernstein understood that classical music needed an evangelist and a face; it's Dudamel's charisma—not his knack for interpreting Chopin—that compels a lunch table of high school students to look up from their sandwiches when he passes them at Lincoln Center during the photo shoot for this profile and shriek. His signature hair helps too. (He confirms he has never used a gel or mousse, but he does make an effort to patronize salons that are familiar with its texture. Once, in Sweden—land of the tall and towheaded—a hairdresser refused to touch a single strand. "I think he saw an alien," Dudamel says.)

Dudamel is humble, but not blind. "Artists have an ego, and it's natural," he says a few days later. He and I are talking about the perils and paradise of Los Angeles, where stars and their self-regard can run wild. Dudamel inherited his mentor Abreu's conviction that music can build bridges and illuminate a better world. "What happens in an orchestra is fascinating," he says. "Different instruments, different cultures, different visions. Different people with different political views. This is the thing we need in the world."

Dudamel's resolute optimism has, at times, looked to his critics like willful blindness. In years past, he faced sharp criticism for continuing to work in Venezuela as its then president Nicolás Maduro suppressed dissent and plunged the population into a series of humanitarian crises. Despite functioning as one of its most prominent, if unofficial, cultural ambassadors, Dudamel remained silent while Venezuela descended into chaos. He resisted the pressure until 2017, when he did at last break with the regime in an op-ed denouncing its antidemocratic crackdown. The government then made clear that he should not visit. When Abreu died in 2018, Dudamel missed the funeral. Even now, he resists commenting on Venezuela's political situation, deflecting to say that his focus is on El Sistema, which relies on government funding, and humanitarian aid. In August, his final performance with the Los Angeles Philharmonic will be a benefit concert for earthquake relief. "There's still a lot of hope there," he says.

He's not naive, just disciplined and decades older than he was when classical music greeted him as a savior. His riot of curls has started to gray. Sometimes, it falls to his teenage son, Martín, to introduce him to new music. (Martín's mother is Dudamel's ex-wife, Eloísa Maturén; he married the Spanish actress and director María Valverde in 2017.) It occurs to Dudamel in the midst of our conversation at the United Palace that he should be exercising more diligently, the better to keep up with his frantic pace. More than once, his emphatic gesticulating has caused tennis elbow.

With perspective, he thinks more now about where orchestral music is headed. "We have to break the idea that classical music is not connected with the present," he says. He can't resist noting that Timothée Chalamet—who overshadowed his own Oscars campaign last year when he said that he didn't want the film business to become something "no one cares about anymore"—was in the audience when Dudamel brought the LA Phil to Coachella. "It's important to show that classical music, ballet, all of these art forms are alive," he says with a grin. "It's our responsibility as a new generation of artists to understand that we cannot be lazy."

Change is inevitable, even when it's hard. He feels this as he prepares to wrap up his long goodbye to Los Angeles, where he has made an incredible number of friends and collaborated with several of them, including Natalie Portman, the director Alejandro González Iñárritu,

the chef and philanthropist José Andrés, and Bradley Cooper and Cate Blanchett—each played conductors in *Maestro* and *Tár,* respectively. Blanchett tells me that she has "never been in the presence of an artist who leads with such joy, such love." He will miss LA, although pieces of it—and people from it—are coming with him. He and his wife have been renting an apartment on the Upper West Side and are planning to remain near Lincoln Center. Julie Andrews laughs when she tells me that she just relocated from Los Angeles to Sag Harbor, New York. Not for Dudamel, she assures me, but it does mean that she will still be able to see him in concert.

When I wonder whether it's difficult to acclimate to New York's fitful weather after decades in temperate LA and tropical Caracas, he thinks for a second and then smiles. Dudamel is attuned to a different kind of atmosphere. Amid one of last winter's blizzards, he sought cover at Tarnopolsky's house, where the president and CEO was at the stove, cooking. "Yes, it was snowing, but it was so warm inside." □

In This Issue

Table of Contents: 92: On Trentini: Coat; erdem.com. Pomellato rings; pomellato.com. On Smalls: Coat; erdem.com. Manicurist: Veronica Butenko. Tailor: Kim Lareau. **112:** Dress and heels; gucci.com. Watch; audemarspiguet.com. Manicurist: Koko Etsuko Shimatani. Tailor: Sara Lassalle. **Cover Look: 112:** On Gerber: Jacket, dress, shoes, and necklaces; select Chanel boutiques. On Gere: Jacket, shirt, trousers, tie, belt, and shoes; 800-550-0005 for inquiries. **Editor's Letter: 130:** Top left image: On Gerber: Coat, shirt, jeans, and belt; chloe.com. Comme Si socks; commesi.com. Chanel shoes; select Chanel boutiques. Mikimoto necklace; mikimotoamerica.com. Watch; omegawatches.com. On Gere: Suit, shirt, and shoes; prada.com. **Contributors: 162:** Top left image: On Cobb: Ralph Lauren Purple Label tuxedo; ralphlauren.com. On Ferguson: Fforme dress; fforme.com. Prounis earrings; prounisjewelry.com. On McGill: Ralph Lauren Purple Label tuxedo; ralphlauren.com. On Rhee: Ralph Lauren Collection dress; ralphlauren.com. Bvlgari jewelry; bulgari.com. On Kim: Chanel dress and shoes; select Chanel boutiques. Bottom right image: On Rawn: Lemaire jacket. Tory Burch top and skirt. Le Monde Béryl shoes. On Kilburn: Chanel top and skirt. Bode shoes. On Giddens: Auralee suit. Lemaire shoes. On Peraza-Webb: Dries Van Noten shirt; driesvan noten.com. Valentino trousers; Valentino boutiques. On Wojcik: Phoebe Philo coat, top, and trousers; phoebephilo.com. Jennifer Behr headband; jennifer behr.com. Bottega Veneta bag. The Row shoes. Tiffany & Co. earrings; select Tiffany & Co. boutiques.

JUST KIDS

277: On Gerber: Cardigan, shirt, and skirt; Dior boutiques. Church's shoes; church-footwear.com. On Gere: Coat, suit, collar, and shoes; Dior boutiques. **278:** Dress, tank top, skirt, socks, and shoes; prada.com. Paula Rowan gloves; paula rowan.com. **279:** Coat and hat; bottegaveneta.com. Herbert Levine shoes; net-a-porter.com. **280:** Jacket, shirt, skirt, and shoes; select Chanel boutiques. Chanel Fine Jewelry earrings and Chanel High Jewelry necklace; select Chanel boutiques. **282:** Jacket and trousers; select Dolce & Gabbana boutiques. Prada shoes. **283:** Dress; Valentino boutiques. Wolford tights. Hat; gigiburris.com. Shoes; net-a-porter.com. Earrings; Cartier boutiques. **284–285:** On Gerber: Top, skirt, and shoes; ysl.com. On Gere: Suit, shirt, tie, and scarf; ysl.com. **286:** Coat; balenciaga.com. Hat; noelstewart.com. Boots; net-a-porter.com for similar styles. **287:** Dress, hat, and necklace; select Louis Vuitton boutiques. Prada shoes. **289:** Jacket, shirt, and trousers; armani.com. **290:** Tops and dress; loewe.com for similar styles. Shoes; manoloblahnik.com. Earrings and rings; select Chanel boutiques. **291:** Top, trousers, and hat; givenchy.com. Church's shoes. **293:** Shirt and skirt; bergdorfgoodman.com. Mikimoto necklace; mikimotoamerica.com. Manicurist: Jin Soon Choi. Tailor: Carol Ai at Carol Ai Studio Tailors.

TRAIN DREAMS

294–295: On Cox: Coat, waistcoat, and trousers; paul smith.com. On Wright: Dress and gloves; maxmara.com. Jimmy Choo shoes; jimmychoo.com. On Thiesen: Coat and dress; akris.com. Christys' Hats hat; christys-hats.com. **296–297:** Waistcoat, shirt, trousers, and tie; armani.com. Church's shoes; church-footwear.com. **298–299:** On Soverall: Gown and bodysuit; missohee.com for appointments. On Walter: Dress; Valentino boutiques. On Wright: Jacket, shirt, and trousers; erdem.com. Prada shoes. **300:** Dress and gloves; givenchy.com. **301:** Cape, collar, and dress; select Valentino boutiques. **302–303:** On Thompson: Jacket; Dover Street Market, New York. On Cox: Moss waistcoat, shirt, and tie; moss.co.uk. Trousers; ralph lauren.com. On Thiesen: Top and dress; select Chanel boutiques. On Wright: Jacket and skirt; daniellefrankelstudio.com. On Madekwe: Jacket, shirt, and trousers; dior.com for similar styles. **304–305:** On Cox: Jacket, waistcoat, and trousers; dunhill.com. On Madekwe: Top and trousers; Valentino boutiques. Dolce & Gabbana shoes; select Dolce & Gabbana boutiques. On Walter: Jacket, dress, and shoes; select Dolce & Gabbana boutiques. Manicurist: Michelle Humphrey. Tailor: Della George.

RAW MATERIAL

306: Vintage tank top from Mothfood Shop; mothfood shop.com. Vintage jeans from eBay; ebay.com for similar styles. **307:** Jeans; mothfood shop.com. **309:** Blazer; brooksbrothers.com. Jake's sweater; 63 Vyner Street, London. **311:** Comme Si boxers; commesi.com. **312:** Jeans; ebay.com for similar styles. Boots; 329 Bowery, New York. **313:** The Quality Mending Co. vintage boots. **316:** Prada tank top; prada.com. **317:** Araks bralette. Manicurist: Jin Soon Choi. Tailor: Francisco Chaydez.

ARYNA UNCHAINED

319: Dress; gucci.com. Earrings; materialgood.com. Manicurist: Koko Etsuko Shimatani. Tailor: Sara Lassalle.

INSIDE DEMNA'S GUCCIVERSE

320–327: Manicurist: Raphaël Park Charles.

THE MATRIARCH

328–329: Dress; ralphlauren.com. Le Monde Béryl shoes; lemondeberyl.com. Manicurist: Sonya Meesh. Tailor: Jacqui Bennett at Carol Ai Studio Tailors.

REMEMBRANCE

330–331: David Hockney, *Le Parc des Sources, Vichy,* 1970, acrylic on canvas, 84 x 120 in. (213.4 x 304.8 cm). © Estate of David Hockney. Photo Credit: Fabrice Gibert.

AHEAD OF THE BEAT

338–339: Coat; Dolce & Gabbana boutiques. Shirt and bow tie; dunhill.com. Church's shoes; church-footwear.com. **340–341:** Shirt; Hermès boutiques. Trousers; armani.com. John Lobb shoes; johnlobb.com. Watch; rolex.com for inquiries. Tailor: Tae Yoshida for Carol Ai Studio Tailors.

REACHING CRESCENDO

342–343: On Cloutier: Shirt; bode.com. Annika Inez earrings; annikainez.com. On Kilburn: Chanel Fine Jewelry earrings; select Chanel boutiques. On Giddens: Auralee sweater and shirt; auralee.jp. Lemaire shoes; lemaire.fr. **344:** On Lyte: Earrings; prounisjewelry.com. **345:** Bracelet; select Tiffany & Co. boutiques. **346:** Necklace; select Tiffany & Co. boutiques. **348:** Lemaire turtleneck; lemaire.fr. Earrings; lie-studio.com. **349:** Earrings; sophie buhai.com. Carmina shoes. **350:** On Kilburn: Dress; fendi.com. Necklace and ring; select Tiffany & Co. boutiques. On Rawn: Dress; celine.com. Watch; bulgari.com. **351:** Watch; Cartier boutiques. **352:** On Wojcik: The Row shoes; the row.com. Prounis earrings; prounisjewelry.com. Lié Studio rings; lie-studio.com. On Zhang: Commission top; commission.nyc. On Wong: Public School New York top; publicschoolnew york.com. **353:** On Beck: Earrings; lie-studio.com. On Rawn: Ring; larasonmez.com. **355:** Prounis earrings; prounisjewelry.com. Manicurist: Dawn Sterling. Tailor: Lyndsea LaMarr.

ALL WRAPPED UP

356–357: Bottega Veneta skirt. Cap; select Louis Vuitton boutiques. Max Mara gloves; maxmara.com. Hermès boots; select Hermès boutiques. **358:** Coats; us.burberry.com. Pants; Bergdorf Goodman. Anonymous Copenhagen boots; us.anoncph.com. Loro Piana necklace; loro piana.com. Ilaria Icardi ring; ilariaicardi.com. **359:** On Smalls: Coat, top, and skirt; victoriabeckham.com. Louis Vuitton hat. Boots; loropiana.com. On Trentini: Coat and sweater; akris.com. Hermès boots. Ilaria Icardi ring. Omega watch. On Miller: Trench coat and pants; celine.com. Lanvin hat. Anonymous Copenhagen boots. **360–361:** Ilaria Icardi ring. **363:** Ganni pants. Anonymous Copenhagen boots. **364–365:** Rings; pomellato.com. **366:** Giorgio Armani fur coat; armani.com. Anonymous Copenhagen boots. Lanvin hat. **367:** Max Mara gloves. Anonymous Copenhagen boots. **368:** Anonymous Copenhagen boots. Pomellato rings. **369:** Anonymous Copenhagen boots. Manicurist: Veronica Butenko. Tailor: Kim Lareau.

LAST LOOK

378: Bag; Valentino boutiques. **380:** Pouch; loewe.com. **381:** Bag; driesvannoten.com for similar styles. **384:** Bag; select Louis Vuitton boutiques. **385:** Pouch; select Dolce & Gabbana boutiques. **388:** Bag; maison-alaia.com. **389:** Bag; fendi.com. **390:** select Chanel boutiques.

CONDÉ NAST IS COMMITTED TO GLOBAL ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY. SCAN HERE FOR DETAILS.

A WORD ABOUT DISCOUNTERS WHILE *VOGUE* THOROUGHLY RESEARCHES THE COMPANIES MENTIONED IN ITS PAGES, WE CANNOT GUARANTEE THE AUTHENTICITY OF MERCHANDISE SOLD BY DISCOUNTERS, AS IS ALWAYS THE CASE IN PURCHASING AN ITEM FROM ANYWHERE OTHER THAN THE AUTHORIZED STORE. THE BUYER TAKES A RISK AND SHOULD USE CAUTION WHEN DOING SO.

Last Look

Valentino Garavani bag

Full send: For fall 2026, Alessandro Michele has gone all-in on jangly juxtapositions, mashing up indulgence with a louche insouciance. Just look at the accessories, which include new iterations of the primly proportioned DeVain bag that showcases winsome floral motifs in a punkish package.

PHOTOGRAPHED BY CHARLES NEGRE

BVLGARI

SERPENTI INFINITO

NEW YORK

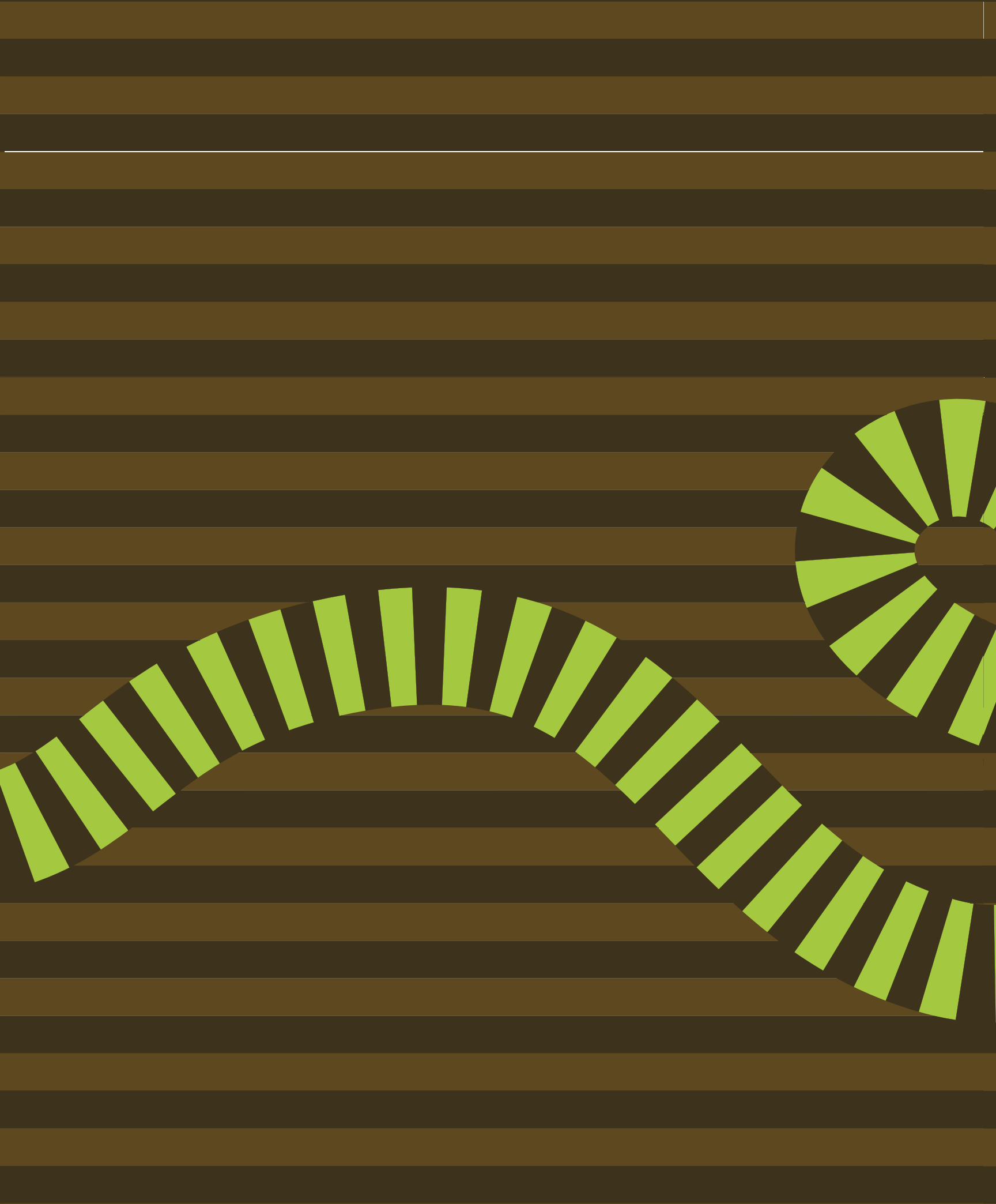
Last Look

Loewe pouch

However intricate its execution, the Andalusian art of flamenco has only three main pillars: *baile* ("dance"), *cante* ("song"), and *toque* ("guitar"). Similarly, whatever the bristling silhouette of this mini Flamenco purse may suggest, it's just one part supple Napa leather, one part embroidery, and a *lot* of joyous movement.

Dries Van Noten bag

Some big days call for even bigger bags, and this one, from Dries Van Noten, is both appropriately capacious (Mary Poppins herself would find it fetching) and as pretty as a painting. Don't bother hedging—just pick it up and wear it right out.



Louis Vuitton bag

Once in a while, it's nice to be square—like when you're a teeny Vuitton trunk, for example. All the craftsmanship is there (in the calfskin trim, the flowers formed from sequins and raffia, the reinforced corners, that classic S-lock)—just shrunken to the handy-dandy dimensions of a minaudière.

Last Look

Dolce & Gabbana pouch

Like the estimable figure from whom it takes its name, Dolce & Gabbana's Nonna bag may be small—but it's mighty. Unflashy in presentation, it's rich with endearing details, from the cheerful floral print on its velvet exterior to the removable mirror hidden within it.

Last Look

Alaïa shoulder bag

Long, lean, yet anything but mean, Alaïa's Le Teckel purse pays playful tribute to the dachshund in name and in shape—while its graphic print, on a nylon twill fabric covered in polyurethane, has a sweet midcentury patina to it.

Fendi bag

The ur-It bag has outdone itself yet again. On the eve of its 30th birthday—the style was introduced in 1997—Fendi's ineffable Baguette is getting all gussied up for fall 2026, coming out dressed in some 51,000 colorful beads stitched into place over 173 hours. Talk about a fun hang.

Last Look

Chanel bag

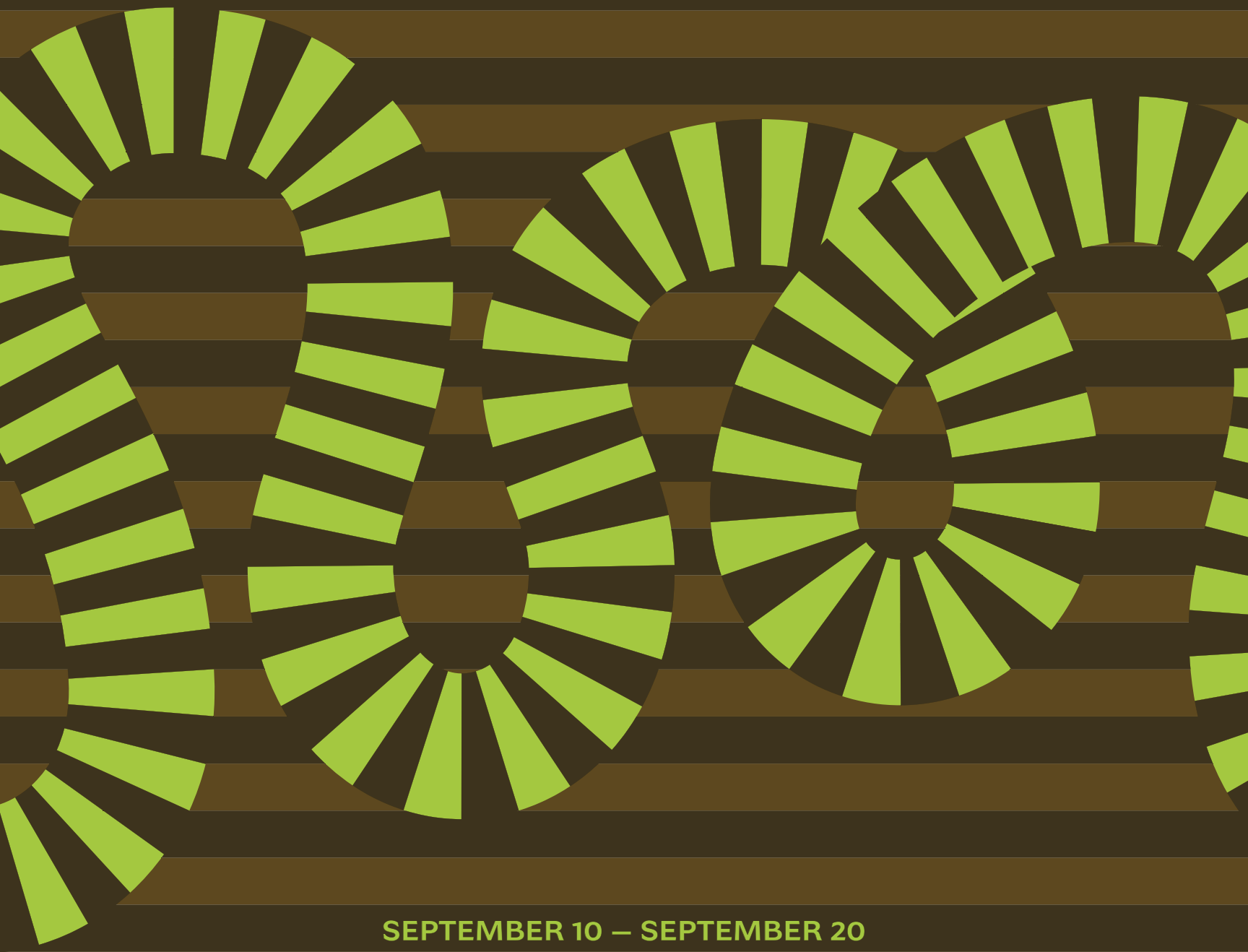
The falling leaves drift by the window / The autumn leaves of… teal *and gold?* Chanel captures the winking transience of a shoulder season in one of its classic flap bags, fashioned from an iridescent, crocodile-embossed calfskin studded with enamel charms.

PRODUCED BY LAMBERT LAMBERT.
SET DESIGN: REMY BRIERE.

BVLGARI

SERPENTI INFINITO

NEW YORK



SEPTEMBER 10 — SEPTEMBER 20

THE HIGH LINE

Dior